

# ► How to support a jobseeker?

Handbook for employment and career development counsellors



*A guide to  
the collection:  
“Building my  
future at work*

# ► How to support a jobseeker?

Handbook for employment and career development  
counsellors



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## ► Preface

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In recent years, successive crises (financial, climatic, health, geopolitical and so on) have hit the global economy and had a powerful impact on the labour market, increasing inequalities. The most disadvantaged populations (young people, women, people with disabilities, the elderly, migrants, refugees and so on) have been the hardest hit. For many, the loss of jobs and income due to the crisis directly threatens their daily survival. Ensuring that these disadvantaged groups are not left behind during the crisis and when the economy recovers is essential to advancing social justice, which is a necessary foundation for the proper functioning of our societies and for sustainable peace.

For the ILO and its constituents, advancing social justice means fair and equal treatment for all; in particular, equal opportunities in accessing the benefits of economic growth, regardless of origin, age, gender, creed, disability and social and economic status, by promoting decent work, respect for fundamental principles and rights at work, fair wages and social protection for all.

Active labour market policies (ALMPs) are essential to promoting equal opportunities by facilitating access to employment for the most disadvantaged. Employment services form an integral part of ALMPs as an implementation mechanism. In addition, public and private employment services are essential to supporting individuals in managing career transitions in a constantly changing market, through career guidance, training and job information. At the same time, they contribute to ensuring that the economy functions better. Employment services are an important labour market institution that contributes to the empowerment of people, connects jobseekers with employers and plays a key role in the functioning of labour markets.

However, we frequently find that the tools and training available to “employment counsellors” in employment services need to be adapted to meet the new challenges of the labour market, linked to the future of work, multiple crises and geopolitical tensions. The ILO has therefore embarked on an initiative aimed at providing a collection of practical guides entitled “Building my future at work” to support “Employment Counsellors”. These publications are available free of charge in several languages on the ILO website.

If you are an “employment counsellor”, this handbook is aimed directly at you, especially if you have been recently recruited. It aims to provide valuable tools for your work in employment services. I am convinced that this publication will be useful in your work and will strengthen your role within the institution of the employment service.

**Ms Sukti DASGUPTA**

Head of the Employment, Labour Market and Youth branch.

**International Labour Organization – Geneva**



## ► Introduction

The world of work is constantly changing. The economy is forced to adapt to environmental, technological, demographic, political and social challenges. New professions are being created, some are disappearing, all are being transformed. In order to successfully manage transitions in their careers, at different points in their working lives, individuals need advice and even coaching. Employment services play a major role in facilitating these transitions and in intermediating between job supply and demand. If you have just taken up a job as an employment counsellor, be proud of the job you are going to do. Your action will have an impact on the professional and personal futures of the many individuals whom you will advise and support.

This manual is yours. More generally, it is aimed at all those involved in professional integration, whether in a public employment service, an association, a private employment agency or a training organization.

In the vast majority of countries there are no training courses to prepare for the profession of professional integration or employment counsellor. Generally, candidates for these positions come from a wide variety of backgrounds and discover the job in situ. In the best of cases, they will benefit from a post-recruitment training cycle to accompany them in their new position. But often they will learn the profession without traditional training, just by observing the practices of their more experienced colleagues.

The aim of this handbook is to provide you with the elements that will help you to understand and practise the job of an employment counsellor. Designed in three complementary parts, it provides you with a conceptual framework, methodological elements and environmental elements. It is designed to be used in conjunction with the two practical guides already published by the ILO (free access on the website):

- How to choose my future profession?
- How to organize my job search?

Of course this manual is not exhaustive. It provides you with the basis for your new job, it provides the knowledge and skills needed to do it, but it does not replace a training course, which every employment counsellor should have.



Finally, like the two practical guides, this manual is designed to be used globally, without reference to any one country or continent. Everyone will have to adapt it to the context and realities of their country and professional environment.

We hope that it will be useful to you as you discover your new profession as a counsellor and build the foundations of your professional practice.

**Mr François DUMORA**  
**Author of the manual**

Employment services specialist  
 Career Guidance Contact Person  
 International Labour Organization – Geneva 2023

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# CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

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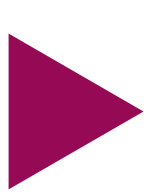
1. The future of work

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# The future of work

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Work: a fundamental right

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Realities of labour around the world

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Impact of crises on workers' situations

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New economies and accelerated change  
in professions

## ► Work: a fundamental right

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On 10 December 1948, the General Assembly of the United Nations adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Article 23 of which states that:

- “Everyone has the right to work, to free choice of employment, to just and favourable conditions of work and to protection against unemployment.
- Everyone, without any discrimination, has the right to equal pay for equal work.
- Everyone who works has the right to just and favourable remuneration ensuring for himself and his family an existence worthy of human dignity, and supplemented, if necessary, by other means of social protection.”

Work is therefore a fundamental right that should enable every human being to live in dignity. The International Labour Organization, created in 1919, is responsible for defending this right. Bringing together representatives of governments, employers and workers from its 187 member states, it negotiates and sets international labour standards, develops policies and designs programmes to advance social justice and promote decent work for all women and men around the world.

## ► Realities of labour around the world

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There is much progress still to be made.

Today, around the world (1)

- 160 million children – 63 million girls and 97 million boys – are engaged in child labour. This equates to more than 1 in 10 children on our planet. Nearly half of them perform work that directly endangers their health, safety and moral development.
- 40.3 million people are victims of modern slavery, including 24.9 million in forced labour and 15.4 million in forced marriage. 1 in 4 victims of modern slavery is a child.
- On average, women are paid 23 per cent less than their male counterparts. Hundreds of millions of people suffer discrimination at work because of their skin colour, ethnic or social origin, religion or political opinion, age, gender, sexual identity or orientation, disability or because they are HIV-positive.

In addition to these most striking situations, the global labour market is characterized above all by a great deal of informality, in other words jobs are worked without declaration to the competent authorities, without any legal or regulatory framework and without social protection. In many countries in the South, informality can account for up to 90 per cent of economic activity. Formal employment is the exception and precariousness the norm. Thus, having a job does not guarantee any escape from poverty and about half of the world's population lives on the equivalent of 2 dollars a day.

In adopting its Sustainable Development Agenda in 2015, the United Nations identified 17 major goals. The eighth aims to promote sustainable and shared economic growth, employment and decent work for all. This target constitutes the guideline for the work of the ILO for the decade.



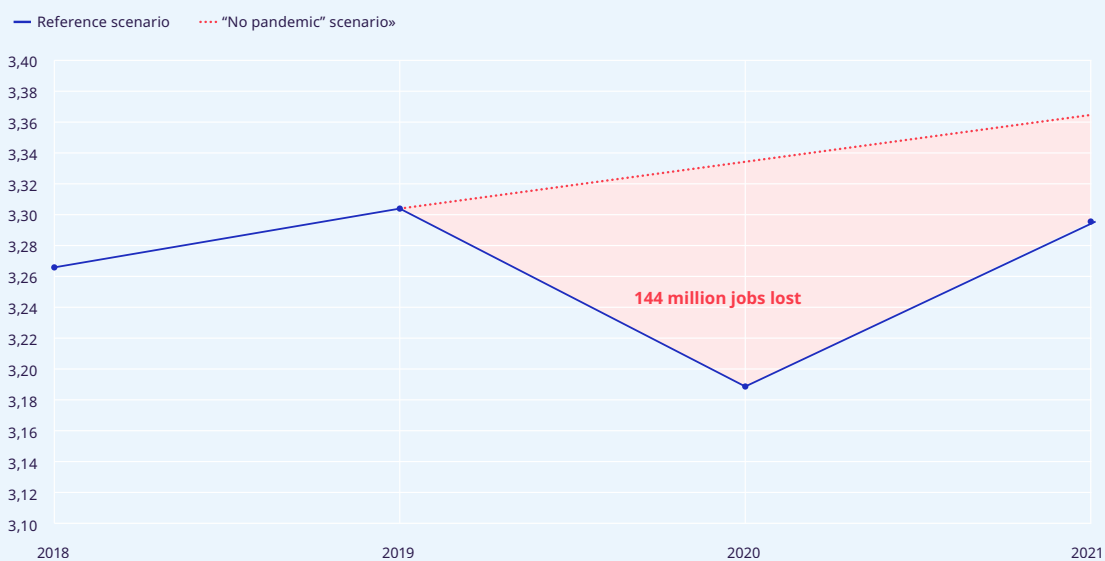
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For queries on usage, contact: dpcampaigns@un.org

## ► Impact of crises on workers' situations

Successive economic, health and geopolitical crises, wars and conflicts systematically degrade workers' situations. The most affected are always the most vulnerable populations: women, young people, people

### ► Global job losses compared to a "no pandemic" scenario, 2018–2021

Jobs are expressed in billions of people



Source: ILO Observatory: COVID-19 and the world of work. Seventh edition •

with disabilities, refugees and migrants. According to the ILO Observatory, more than 144 million jobs were lost globally as a result of the COVID-19 crisis between 2019 and 2021 (2).

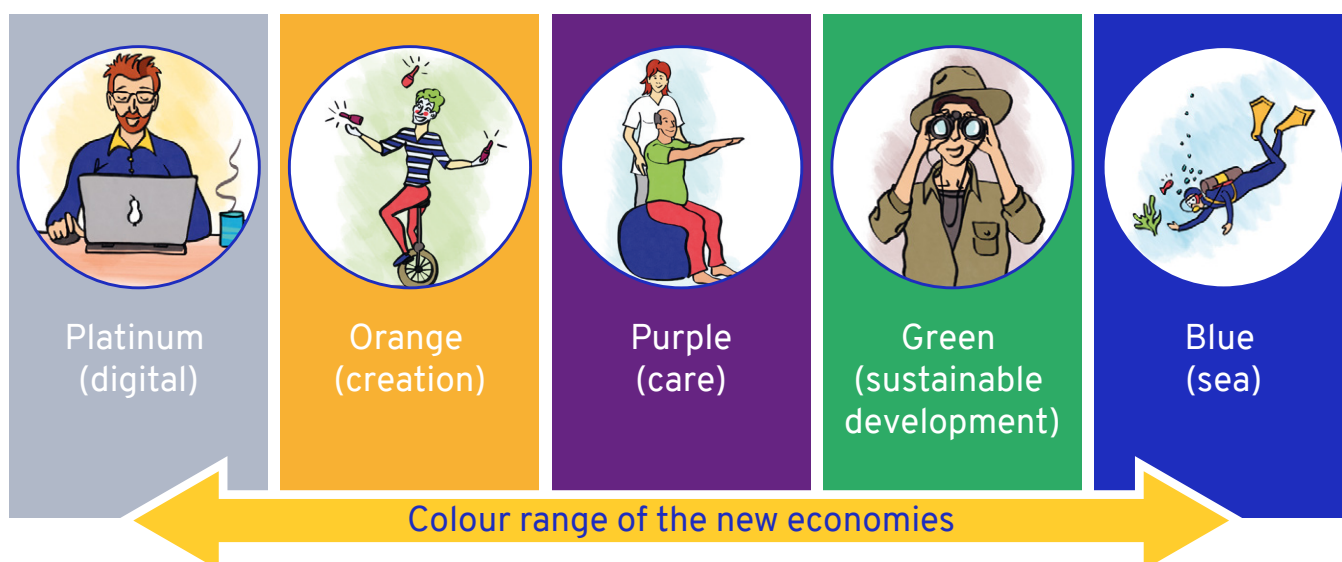
But the climate crisis is probably the greatest challenge of our time. Because of the environmental degradation it causes, climate change poses a considerable risk to the economy by reducing productivity and destroying jobs.

Droughts, heat waves, heavy rainstorms, tropical cyclones, rising sea levels, increasing temperatures and changes in rainfall patterns all displace workers, disrupt business activities, damage business equipment and infrastructure and negatively impact productivity, the labour market and employment. Moreover, as in all crises, the effects disproportionately impact upon the most vulnerable, especially women.

While the situation may appear very bleak, it is all the more important to be prepared for it, not least because the fight against climate change can also create many jobs. According to a 2019 ILO report (3), replacing fossil fuels with renewable energy and promoting a circular economy, which involves using resources in a sustainable and recyclable way, would create more than 103 million new jobs worldwide.

## ► New economies and accelerated change in professions

The main characteristic of the future of work is an intense acceleration in the evolution of professions, which will mainly be linked to technological innovations. All sectors and almost all professions are impacted by the possibilities offered by digital technology. Many professions are transforming, others are disappearing and new ones are being created.



(Source: ILO – Global Youth Employment Forum – Abuja, Nigeria, 2019)

At the heart of the evolution of professions, we can distinguish the growing importance of five economic sectors that will be of major importance over the coming decades:

- ✓ **The digital economy (platinum)** : this covers Information and Communication Technologies (ICT), including the computing, electronics and telecommunications sectors, as well as all uses generated by the Internet, applications and social networks.
- ✓ **The green economy** : this includes activities that produce goods or services for environmental protection or sustainable management of natural resources, as well as traditional activities that transform their practices for better environmental quality.
- ✓ **The blue economy** : this consists in the sustainable use of ocean resources for economic growth, improved incomes and jobs and healthy ocean ecosystems: seafood, transport, tourism, energy, shipbuilding and so on.
- ✓ **The care economy (purple)** : boosted by global demographics, the need for childminders and carers for the elderly is increasing worldwide, generating a large number of jobs over the coming years.
- ✓ **The creative economy (orange)** : the set of activities consisting in transforming ideas into cultural goods and services. The multiplication of communication, leisure and cultural exchange media gives ideas and intellectual production unprecedented economic weight

Employment professionals need to be aware of this context in order to support workers and jobseekers in these new realities.

The days of “a job for life in the same company” no longer exist. These days, it is estimated that each employee will have to change job and/or profession at least five times during their career. This figure tends to increase regularly. Each employee must therefore keep abreast of the latest developments in their sector of activity and profession. They must continuously update their skills so as not to be overtaken by technological developments and to be able to bounce back to deal with unforeseen circumstances. In general, they must remain alert to opportunities that will be the basis for transferring their skills to other positions and other professions. Workers must be the pilots of their professional lives and not mere passengers.



## ► 2 Individuals and unemployment

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Cycle of reactions to job loss

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Vulnerable groups

During the “30 glorious years”, as they are known in France (1945 to 1975), when many countries’ economies were booming and employment was plentiful, the situation of the unemployed was often looked upon with disdain. It could be said that the unemployed were considered either unlucky and unresourceful or lazy and content to live off wider society. Then came the economic crises and mass unemployment set in, almost as a matter of course.

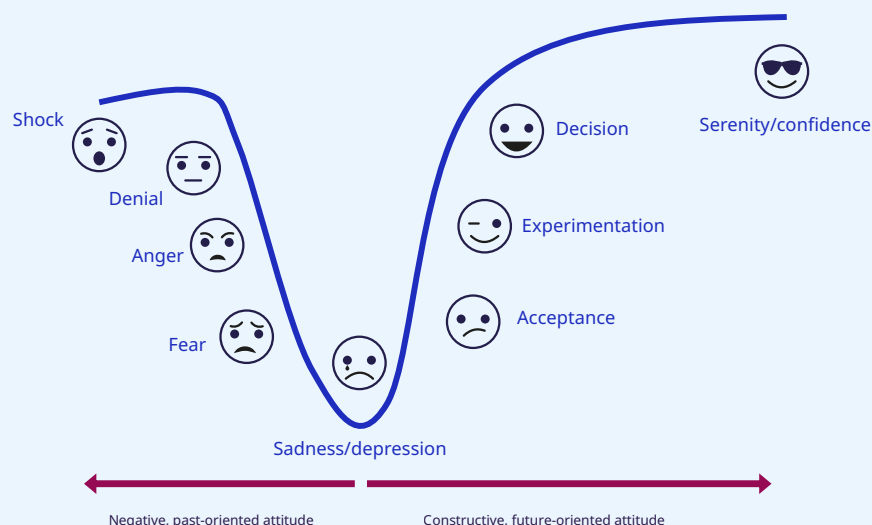
Today, even when the economy is improving, no one is immune to job loss. As explained earlier, the labour market is so fluid, and occupations change so quickly, that few individuals do not experience one or more periods of unemployment during their career. If it is anticipated, this transition situation can be experienced as a break, a stage that can be used to give a new direction to one’s career, to move on to another sector, or even another profession, and to develop new skills. However, job loss is often not anticipated by the individual. It is often experienced as a trauma.

## ► Cycle of reactions to job loss

For all of us, having a job is first and foremost a source of income that should enable us to meet the unavoidable expenses of daily life (food, housing, children’s education, health and so on). In addition to meeting these primary needs, work also contributes to personal development and fulfilment. Work provides a social status and an identity. It is therefore an important element of psychological well-being. This is why the announcement of redundancy and the arrival of unemployment can be very difficult for any individual: fears for one’s finances, anxieties about the uncertainty of finding a job quickly, loss of identity and so on.

The newly unemployed person will go through intense emotional phases before being able to “mourn” the lost job, move on and bounce back. The work of the American-Swiss psychiatrist Elisabeth Kübler-Ross is reference literature on this subject. She identifies the stages of the grieving process in the loss of a loved one, which are transposed to the loss of a job and more generally to any situation of change.

### ► Grieving process or stages of change – inspired by Elisabeth Kübler-Ross



It is assumed that each individual necessarily goes through the various stages of this process. The difference between individuals is the time spent on each stage. For some it may be a few minutes, for others several days, weeks or months. Some people remain permanently stuck in the denial, anger or sadness stage, thus sinking into a depression phase.

- 1. The shock:** the individual experiences announcement of the dismissal as something brutal. They do not understand what is happening to them. They are in shock.
- 2. Denial:** they are in negation. They do not accept the reality of the dismissal. A great sense of injustice overwhelms them. "It's not possible" – "Why me?"
- 3. Anger :** they let their anger out, and sometimes look for people to blame.
- 4. Fear:** they fear for their future; fear that they will not be able to find another job; fear that they will not be able to cover their expenses; and so on.
- 5. Depression/sadness:** they feel powerless and finally give up and/or complain. This stage is special because it closes the downward phase of the curve. It is at this point that the individual grasps the inescapable nature of the change: either they consent to it and accept the impact on their daily life, or they remain locked into their frustration.
- 6. Acceptance:** at the beginning of the upward phase, they begin to change their point of view. Maybe the change isn't such a bad thing?.
- 7. Experimentation:** through experimentation, they identify the opportunities and benefits of the new situation. They can take advantage of this to bounce back.
- 8. The decision :** this is it, they are taking a new look at their job loss. They have come to terms with their past and are now looking to the future. This is the time to take stock of your expectations and desires in relation to work. "Do I continue in this way? Should I do something else?" And so on.
- 9. Serenity and confidence:** the change has finally been assimilated. The individual has achieved serenity and confidence regarding their new situation. They are excited about their new projects.

It is essential for employment professionals to be fully aware of this grieving process in relation to job loss, in order to take it into consideration when welcoming a new jobseeker. Depending on the phase in which they find themselves, the individual will be more or less available, psychologically, to invest in the stages of their return to employment.

## ► Vulnerable groups

Although article 1 of the Declaration of Human Rights states that “All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights”, the facts show that this equality does not extend to the labour market, because it is a market and it works according to the laws of supply and demand. Thus, the most qualified and experienced, as well as the most resourceful and influential and so on, have a competitive advantage. In this race for jobs, those who remain without a decent job solution are often the same: young people without experience, women, senior citizens, people with disabilities, migrants and refugees, ethnic minorities, LGBT people and so on.

The role of a public employment service is to promote equity and inclusion in the labour market. As a public service, it will therefore pay special attention to these vulnerable groups and implement active policies to guide them and promote their access to employment.

► **Young people (between 15 and 24 years old according to the UN definition) :** Whatever the

continent, youth unemployment is still higher than for the population as a whole. Access to a first job is a major obstacle. The situation of young people who have left the school system and are neither in employment nor in training (known by the acronym NEET) is of particular concern to governments, which are deploying specific measures to support them, such as the "Youth Guarantee" created by the European Union countries.



- **Women :** Women have more difficulty entering the labour market because of a combination of obstacles, often stemming from social organization: less access to education, the burden of bringing up children and running the household, and limited access to certain occupations. Although the employment situation of women has improved dramatically over the past 50 years, gaps still remain. Gender equality in access to work must be a central pillar of employment policies and all discrimination must be combated; this begins with the assertion that professions have no gender. All jobs must be equally accessible to women and men!

► **Seniors** : In the world of work, the term “senior” is used in two ways:

► Either to recognize a high level of expertise in a profession, mainly due to several years of professional experience. For example: “senior consultant”

► Or to designate an age group: usually workers arriving in the last decade before retirement age. Several phenomena affect these groups, hindering their retention in or access to employment:

- ✓ Because of their seniority in the company, their salary level is often higher than that of the average employee. They are often the first victims of redundancy plans.
- ✓ In physically demanding occupations, they often find it difficult to remain in employment until retirement age due to physical illness or pain.
- ✓ Technological change is also an obstacle to their retention when the company and the employee have not been able to update the latter’s skills throughout their career..



Northern countries are the most affected by the ageing of populations and the phenomenon of underemployment of older people. They are trying to develop incentive policies to keep them employed until retirement age.

► **Persons with disabilities** : According to ILO Convention No. 159, adopted in 1983, “the term disabled person means an individual whose prospects of securing, retaining and advancing in suitable employment are substantially reduced as a result of a duly recognised physical or mental impairment.” This same convention, already ratified by 85 countries around the world, encourages policies on :

- The vocational rehabilitation of people with disabilities.
- Positive measures aimed at equal opportunities and the promotion of employment opportunities for people with disabilities in the open labour market.

In practice, State policies to promote access to employment for people with disabilities are mainly based on three strategies :

- Obliging companies and administrations to have a minimum percentage of persons with disabilities in their workforce.
- Implementing incentives to hire or keep persons with disabilities in employment: adaptation of workstations, financial aid and so on.
- Creating and subsidizing specific work structures to accommodate, in suitable conditions, persons whose disability is too severe to be considered for a job in a traditional company.

► **Migrants and refugees** : Human history is made up of migrations. Famine and insecurity, often caused by wars or climatic disasters, have always been the main reasons for people to flee to territories considered more favourable. The phenomenon continues in our time and is likely to increase as a result of global climate change. Although we are all descendants of migrants, the reception and integration of these populations into the society and economy of the country of arrival is often problematic. Depending on the legislation, they are not always allowed to work. Employment services have a role to play in developing humanistic policies to integrate these populations into decent work.



# ▶ 3 Supporting professional integration

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Employment services

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Range of PES services

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Focus on career guidance

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Focus on the skills-based approach

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Focus on the labour market

Labour market integration is a process that permits an individual to “find their place” in the labour market; in other words, to find a professional activity corresponding to their ambitions and skills, for a period of time in line with their project.

According to Claude TROTTIER, Louise LAFORCE and Renée CLOUTIER (5), the three criteria that characterize successful professional integration are: stability in the job found, the training/job match and the construction of a professional identity. This third point should be stressed. Indeed, professional integration appears to be a socialization process. It would allow a young person to truly move into adulthood and find a certain recognition by their peers through identification with a profession and a professional environment. One of the challenges of professional integration would therefore be to enable integration into society.

As for the stability criterion, which is often understood as the signing of a long-term employment contract, it has long been a prerequisite for successful integration. This is probably less the case today, as we know that the labour market is changing and that a professional life is made up of many stages. In addition, many young people no longer wish to be locked into a permanent contract. They prefer to multiply the number of fixed-term contracts and life experiences. Generations Y and Z have always understood, since birth, that the world of work only promises them unemployment and hardship; the prospect of a permanent contract is therefore not their ideal. Without confidence in the future, many young people prefer to live in the moment, both in their private lives and at work, and prefer to 'zap' from contract to contract. They are nonetheless professionally integrated, if this situation corresponds to a non-constrained choice.

## ► Employment services

Depending on the country and the context, the “galaxy” of organizations involved in professional integration support may vary but is generally vast (see chapter 11) and made up of entities that are either generalists or specialized in a certain sector of society or of activity. In most cases, the Public Employment Service (PES) is the central pillar.

The centrality of the PES is given by ILO Convention No. 88 (6). Adopted in 1948 and ratified by 92 countries, it very precisely defines the obligations of a government to deploy a free, local public employment service,

### Article 1

1. Each Member of the International Labour Organization for which this Convention is in force shall maintain a free public employment service or cause one to be maintained.
2. The essential task of the employment service shall be to achieve, in cooperation with other interested public and private bodies where appropriate, the best possible organization of the labour market as an integral part of the national programme for securing and maintaining full employment and for developing and utilizing productive resources.

### Article 2

The employment service shall be a national system of employment offices under the control of a national authority.

### Article 3

1. The system should include a network of local offices and, where appropriate, regional offices, sufficient in number to serve each geographical region of the country and conveniently located for employers and workers.

Source: Excerpt from ILO Convention No. 88.

taking the form of a network of agencies deployed throughout the country, ensuring the best possible organization of the labour market, in order to promote full employment.

For a government, an Employment Service is a valuable and indispensable tool for dealing with one of the most problematic issues in our societies: unemployment. It is a strategy for taking care of those who need it most and deploying active labour market policies. It is therefore an instrument for social justice.

### Main tasks of the PES :

- ▶ Helping to reduce unemployment and strengthen the economy :
  - ▶ Through intermediation, facilitating the meeting of employers and jobseekers
  - ▶ Through skills development programmes, promoting the matching of supply and demand.
- ▶ Promoting equity in the labour market for the most vulnerable groups
  - ▶ Providing transparency by disseminating information on the realities of the labour market
  - ▶ Advising/supporting the less autonomous
  - ▶ Promoting career guidance
  - ▶ Regulating the market with incentives to hire priority groups: young people, women, senior citizens, the disabled and so on.



### ▶ Range of PES services

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Although written in 1948, Convention No. 88 is still very much up to date with regard to the description (article 6) of the range of services to be provided by a PES:

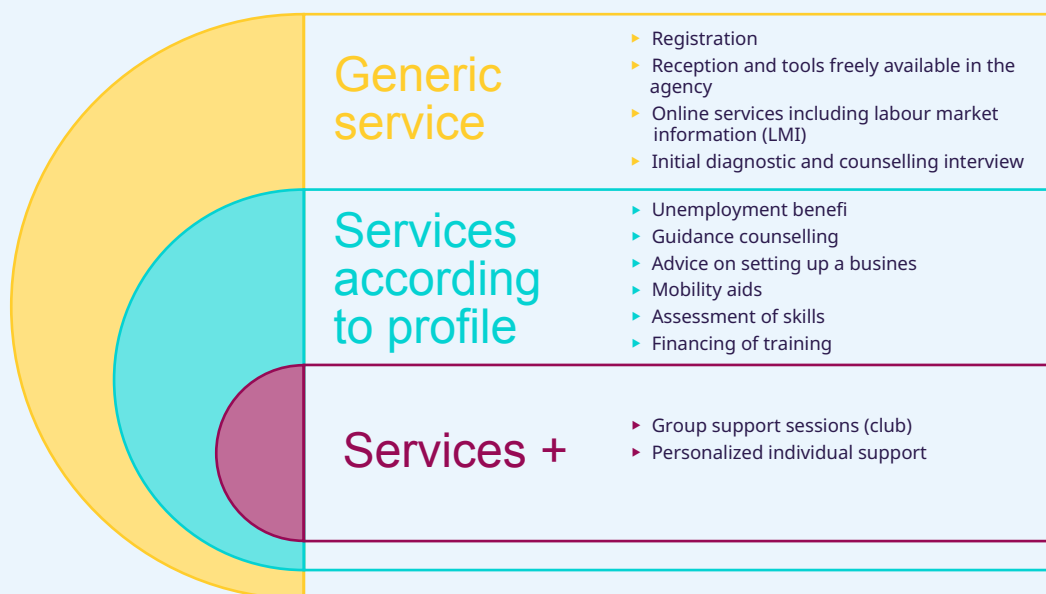
- ▶ Registration of jobseekers
- ▶ Intermediation
- ▶ Assessment of skills
- ▶ Career guidance
- ▶ Training
- ▶ Registration and processing of job offers
- ▶ Professional mobility
- ▶ Geographical mobility

- ▶ International mobility
- ▶ Labour market information
- ▶ Unemployment insurance

The PES has two clients, the jobseeker and the employer. Over the decades, service offers have been refined to meet the needs of each client, based on a segmentation approach. This means that it is considered that not everyone has the same needs and that it is therefore necessary to be able to offer different levels of services, depending on the individual's needs and degree of autonomy.

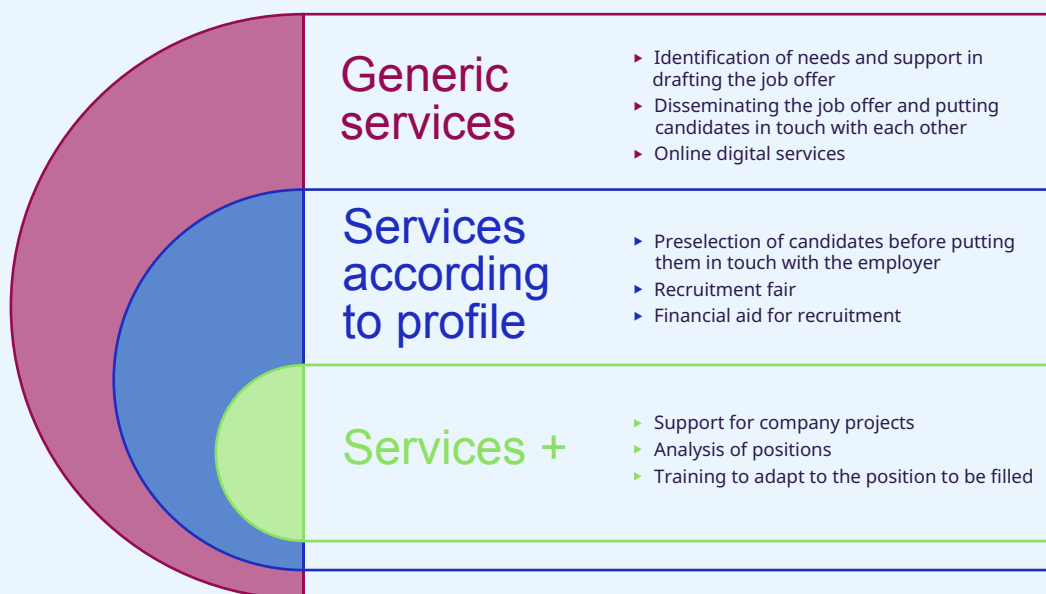
### Types of services frequently offered to jobseekers by PES :

The same logic is deployed for the service to employers. It is indeed understandable that the support to be given to a recruiter will be different, depending on whether it is a craft company with 6 employees or an SME (small and medium-sized enterprise) with 220 employees and its own recruitment department.



## Types of services frequently offered to employers by PES :

However, it should be noted that the priorities of PES are often directed more towards jobseekers. The service offer for employers is generally much less developed, but also less used. The underuse of PES services by employers is one of the major problems faced by these services. Indeed, in order to fulfil their role as intermediaries and act effectively on the labour market, PES need to collect job offers. If the volume of job offers entrusted to PES by employers is too low, the system cannot function properly. PES therefore face a major challenge in convincing employers to entrust them with recruitment. To do this, the employer must be aware of the PES service offer and have confidence in its ability to provide relevant, quality responses within a reasonable time frame. Improving the service they provide to employers is one of the main challenges for PES in the coming years, especially in the context of labour shortages in some economic sectors



## ► Focus on career guidance

Depending on the country, culture and language, the term “career guidance” covers a wide range of services and activities :

- At the very least, it will be a matter of supporting an individual in “defining their professional project”; in other words, reflecting on their choice of future profession.
- This is often accompanied by advice on how to develop the training plan needed to make the project a reality.
- Finally, mainly in English-speaking countries, the concept may include support for project implementation, particularly regarding job search strategies and techniques.

### ► Different components of career guidance



According to UNESCO (7), the practice of **career guidance** is based on the following principles:

1. Human beings have the capacity and opportunity to make choices concerning their careers. The range of options depends in part on individuals' social, economic and cultural situation.
2. These options and choices should be open to all, regardless of gender, socioeconomic class, religion, disability, sexual orientation, age or cultural background.
3. Career options are open to individuals throughout their lives.
4. Over the course of their lives, human beings typically take on a wide range of roles in the world of work, which may or may not be remunerated.
5. Counsellors help individuals to study, pursue and achieve their career goals.
6. There are essentially four elements to career guidance:
  - Helping individuals to become more aware of their interests, values and abilities, as well as their own personality.
  - Providing students with access to resources so that they can be better informed about trades and professions.
  - Involving students in the decision-making process so that they can choose a career that is well suited to their own areas of interest, values, abilities and personality.
  - Helping individuals to manage their careers well (including managing transitions between stages and balancing their various social roles) and to become lifelong learners by enhancing their professional development throughout their lives.
7. The reasons why individuals enter certain occupations vary according to the importance that they attach either to personal preferences and areas of interest or to external influences, such as labour market trends or parental expectations.
8. Choosing a career is not a single decision in a person's life but rather an ongoing process that can take place at any age.
9. All professions are useful and contribute to the success and well-being of a society.

Each individual should be free to choose an occupation corresponding to their personality, without restriction or discrimination. It is essential to understand that career guidance is not just for school leavers. Working lives generally span more than 40 years. Each individual will therefore have to make choices along the way, manage transitions and train and orient themselves throughout their lives. Knowing how to orientate oneself is a skill that everyone must acquire in order to mitigate the impacts of life's vagaries.

In the areas of career guidance, the role of the employment services is.

- ▶ To provide information on professions, trends and realities in the labour market
- ▶ To provide advice and support to individuals whenever necessary
- ▶ To help individuals acquire the competence to orientate themselves autonomously in order to best manage the transitions that they will face during their career.

## ► Focus on the skills-based approach

The acceleration of changes in the labour market is rapidly transforming professions. Education and vocational training systems are often not responsive enough to adapt curricula and syllabuses. The diploma thus loses its relevance and importance in favour of acquired and practised skills. “The skills-based approach” means going beyond diplomas to focus on skills and abilities to act in a professional situation.

A survey of companies in France showed that 57 per cent of recruiters look primarily at behavioural skills in the selection phase, before technical skills.

### ► The 3 skills most sought after by recruiters



## ► Focus on the labour market

Is work a commodity like any other? The use of the expression “labour market” could indeed lead one to believe that the price of an hour of work should be determined, like the price of a ton of wheat, according to the laws of the market, by searching for a balance between the supply of labour (offered by workers) and the demand for labour (expressed by employers). This is the thesis defended by theorists of neoclassical economics, which emerged at the end of the nineteenth century. They advocate pure and perfect competition that would eliminate unemployment and achieve full employment. For the neoclassicals (Pareto, Marshall, Friedman and others), the labour market should self-regulate and there should be total wage flexibility. They therefore denounce any barriers to this market, such as regulations concerning weekly hours or dismissals, the setting of a minimum wage, or the introduction of any social benefits that might encourage voluntary unemployment.

But workers are not tons of grain. They are human beings with a right to decent work. When neoclassical theory is applied, workers can end up being obliged to accept a price per hour and working conditions that do not permit them to live decently. All the more so as there is an asymmetry in the negotiation between employers and employees (8). Alone, the employee is often at a disadvantage in negotiations. Their often precarious situation does not usually allow them to negotiate their skills at a fair price. Their precariousness forces them to accept lesser conditions. Regulation is necessary and must take the form of State intervention. This is supported by the theories developed by John Maynard Keynes, notably in his “General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money”.

In 1919, at the end of the First World War and on the occasion of the Treaty of Versailles, the International Labour Organization was created on the basis of the idea that there can be no lasting and universal peace without social justice. Much of the International Labour Organization’s work over the past 100

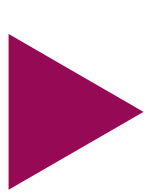
years has consisted in negotiating international labour law rules to regulate the market, protect workers and promote decent work. A total of 190 international conventions have been approved by tripartite representatives of governments, employers and workers. They prohibit forced labour, fight against child labour and discrimination, and advocate the right to association, the right to paid holidays, the setting of a minimum wage and a maximum number of working hours per week and so on. Each member country is invited to ratify these conventions in order to integrate them into its national labour law.

State regulation and joint negotiations between social partners are therefore necessary in the labour market, in order to ensure a fair relationship when negotiating employment contracts and to avoid abuse. With these limitations in mind, the supply/demand ratio remains an important market factor. This is frequently seen in so-called shortage occupations in many sectors (IT, health, catering and so on), in which the scarcity of trained operational people has led to an increase in the level of wages offered by employers.

Labour is therefore not a commodity like any other, but it does react to the laws of the market, which must be framed by regulatory limits and parity agreements to avoid abuse.

The profession of counsellor exists in many professional fields in both the market and non-market sectors. Whether working in a bookshop, a funeral parlour, a farm or an employment agency, the counsellor always plays the same role. An expert in their field, they greet their client, listen to their expressed expectations and ask questions to identify and define their real need, before recommending a service or product suited to the individual's needs. They provide the client with useful information and can, if necessary, refer them to other more relevant structures. They are guided in their actions by concern for client satisfaction.





## The counselling profession

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Different names and places of activity  
in the professional integration sector

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Activities of the employment  
counsellor

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Skills and knowledge of the  
employment counsellor

## ► Different names and places of activity in the professional integration sector

In the field of employment, different names are used. Each of them underlines, in its title, a specificity in the exercise of the profession, but they are in the same professional family :

- ✓ **Employment counsellor**
- ✓ **Career transition counsellor**
- ✓ **Outplacement consultant**
- ✓ **Company counsellor**
- ✓ **Corporate Relations Officer**
- ✓ **Professional integration counsellor**
- ✓ **Socioprofessional integration counsellor**
- ✓ **Employment officer**
- ✓ **Youth employment counsellor and so on**



While ILO Convention No. 88 commits each country to creating, organizing and providing a Public Employment Service, which generally takes the form of a specialized public establishment or a State administration, other types of structures are also involved in the field of employment, with teams made up of counsellors :

- **Private employment agencies:** these are generally commercial and profit-oriented structures that operate to match labour supply and demand, either nationally or internationally. Some also employ workers for the purpose of making them available to a third party or user company. ILO Convention No. 181 sets out the rules for the operation of these structures.
- **Socioprofessional support structures :** these are private companies or associative structures that provide support to people who are generally not very autonomous, in groups or individually, to help them find employment. These structures are often specialized in supporting specific groups (young people, workers with disabilities, women, migrants and so on) and receive funding from the State or private donors to carry out their missions. They may also act as subcontractors to public employment services. They support individuals in their search for employment, but also often help to resolve social problems blocking their integration. Certain of these structures operate within the framework of Insertion par l'Activité Economique (Integration through Economic Activity) mechanisms.
- **Vocational training centres :** the mission of vocational training organizations is mainly focused on teaching and learning. However, some of them also recruit integration counsellors to prepare their trainees for the labour market after graduation.

## ► Activities of the employment counsellor

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As mentioned above, the job of employment counsellor can take several forms related to the professional context or the type of public served. However, there is a professional core that we will try to describe here.

### Main mission :

To promote access or return to employment for jobseekers and recruitment for companies, through counselling and intermediation.

### Core professional activities :

- Receiving, informing and guiding users (jobseekers or employers)
- Conducting counselling interviews
- Performing and sharing a diagnosis, identifying the main needs, obstacles and the strategies
- Providing advice or proposing appropriate support actions to promote professional integration or recruitment
- Jointly constructing an action plan with the user that is suited to their needs and to their project
- Providing advice on careers and choosing a profession
- Providing advice on job-seeking techniques
- Providing information on the labour market
- Informing the user, in a personalized manner, about the existing range of services, employment aids, training and recruitment aids, digital services and so on.
- Advising and supporting them in the use of digital tools and services
- Following up on actions planned with the user
- Organising and hosting informative meetings
- Organising and facilitating thematic group workshops.



### Activities specific to certain variants of the profession :

- ▶ Counselling on career guidance
- ▶ Conducting a skills assessment
- ▶ Defining training needs and establishing a training project
- ▶ Prospecting for companies
- ▶ Analysing a workstation
- ▶ Defining human resources needs
- ▶ Advising on the formulation of a job offer
- ▶ Carrying out sourcing operations
- ▶ Preselecting candidates for recruitment
- ▶ Conducting a recruitment interview
- ▶ Implementing outplacement actions following redundancies
- ▶ Accompanying jobseekers and employers towards autonomy in their approaches.

Historically, public employment services restricted their scope of activity to professional integration and the activity of employment counsellors did not extend to social integration issues. However, certain structures, mainly associations, are already active in both areas: social and professional. In addition, new policy guidelines aim to promote a holistic approach, encouraging a holistic approach to the jobseeker's problems, identifying in particular the social barriers that may slow down their access to the labour market. Thus, employment services, alone or in partnership with services specialising in social issues, are increasingly offering comprehensive support for individuals, who receive guidance in resolving their social issues, while they seek work.

## ► Skills and knowledge of the employment counsellor

In order to carry out the different activities of their job, employment counsellors must acquire specific skills, consisting of theoretical knowledge, know-how and know how to be. The most important of these skills are listed in the table below.

| Theoretical knowledge                        | Know-how                                                       | Know how to be         |
|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Concepts of labour law                       | Interview and communication techniques                         | Sense of human contact |
| Professional training legislation            | Individual coaching                                            | Listening              |
| Tools and techniques for jobseeking          | Group facilitation                                             | Empathy                |
| Psychosociology of the jobseeker             | Support for developing professional projects                   | Open-mindedness        |
| Knowledge of vulnerable groups               | Management of difficult audiences                              | Respect                |
| Operation and trends of the labour market    | Commercial approach to business                                | Kindness               |
| Knowledge of professional integration actors | Use of digital tools and social networks useful for jobseeking | Congruence             |
| Ethics of public officials                   | Use of remote communication tools                              | Rigour                 |
| Anti-discrimination                          | Teamworking                                                    | Reactivity             |
|                                              |                                                                | Organization           |
|                                              |                                                                | Autonomy               |
|                                              |                                                                | Stress management      |

## ► Focus on :

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- **Professional ethics:** Employment counsellors must at all times maintain the strictest level of confidentiality regarding all aspects of their discussions with jobseekers. They should only obtain information that is essential to help the jobseeker make the transition into the labour market and this information should remain confidential even after the counselling relationship has ended. No third party should have access to this information. The same rules apply to the relationship with the employer. Precautions should be taken to ensure that all information entered into computer databases is stored securel.
- **Anti-discrimination :** Employment counsellors, especially if they are public officials, must participate in the fight against existing discrimination in the labour market and, above all, not contribute to it. ILO Convention No. 111, adopted in 1958, states that “the term ‘discrimination’ includes.. any distinction, exclusion or preference made on the basis of race, colour, sex, religion, political opinion, national extraction or social origin, which has the effect of nullifying or impairing equality of opportunity or treatment in employment or occupation”. Since then, other criteria have been considered discriminatory: age, sexual orientation, place of residence, state of health, disability and so on. Concerning access to employment and the selection of candidates, only the candidate’s skills and qualifications should be considered.





## METHODOLOGICAL ELEMENTS

5. Coordination of services to the jobseeker

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6. Analysis and diagnosis interview

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7. Personalized support

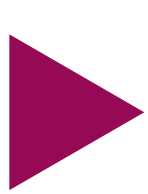
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8. Support with the professional project

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9. Support with jobseeking

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## 5 Coordination of services to jobseekers



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First contact with the employment service

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Principles of support

Why do some unemployed people not take the step of contacting an employment agency? Three main reasons are generally given:

1. The remoteness and difficulty of access to these agencies.
2. Lack of information about the existence of these agencies and the services that they offer
3. Lack of confidence in the ability of these agencies to provide quality services and effective solutions.

In contrast, what are the main expectations of those who walk through the door of an employment agency? :

- ▶ To register in the employment service files in order to be identified as a jobseeker and to be able to benefit from services and proposals
- ▶ To find job vacancies
- ▶ To receive unemployment benefit, where available
- ▶ To receive advice from employment experts
- ▶ To access training
- ▶ To access information on the labour market, professions, training courses and so on.

## ▶ First contact with the employment service

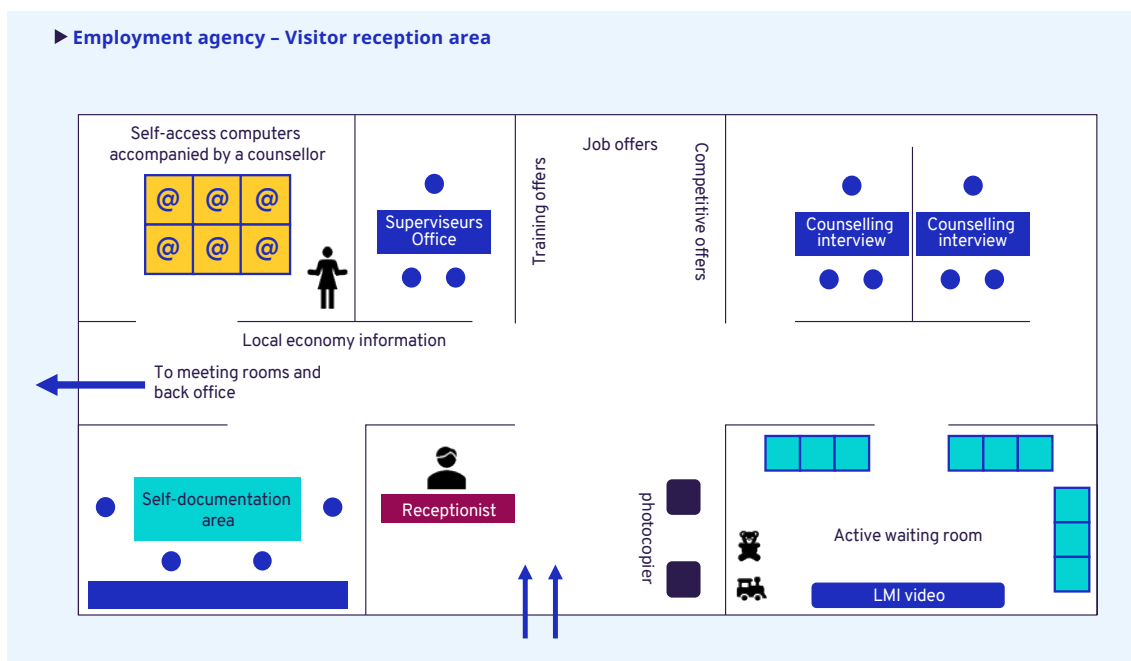
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Depending on the country and the organization, there are three different ways of making contact:

- ▶ **Via the Internet** : the jobseeker has to register on the PES website by filling in an online questionnaire and uploading supporting documents, such as identity documents, work certificates and so on. After this step, an appointment for a personal interview will be offered, sometimes combined with an informative meeting.
- ▶ **By telephone** : The applicant calls a telephone platform. They have an initial interview with a counsellor to carry out an administrative pre-registration. An appointment is made for a personal interview, during which they will have to present supporting documents.
- ▶ **Physical reception** : The applicant goes directly to an employment agency. They are received by a receptionist who identifies their expectations and directs them to the most appropriate contact person. They will be registered by a counsellor, either immediately or by appointment.

On their first visit to an employment agency, the jobseeker may discover a place that is similar to a resource centre. Indeed, an employment agency is not just a building in which administrative procedures are carried out. It should be a welcoming and user-friendly space providing many services as well as information, as shown in the following diagram :

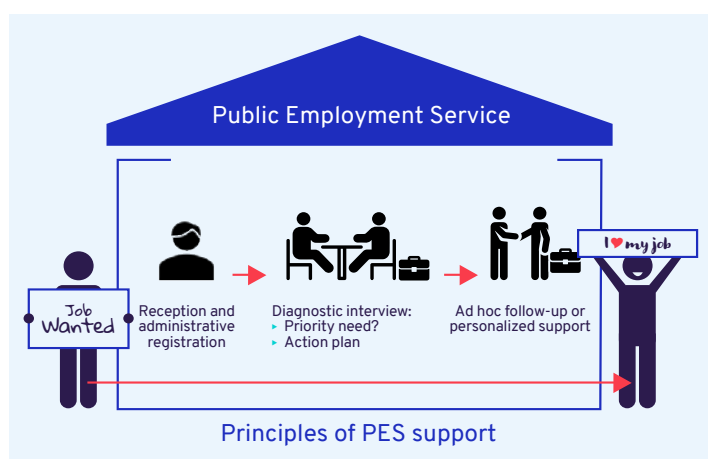
- ▶ Notice boards for job offers, training offers and competitive offers
- ▶ Free access tools: photocopier, computers to consult websites dedicated to jobseeking, information on the labour market, training and so on
- ▶ “Active waiting” areas, enabling people to wait while watching films on professions, consulting specialized magazines, and so on
- ▶ Self-documentation spaces.



## ► Principles of support

After initial contact, the jobseeker can expect to receive an often similar support process, regardless of the country. The three main steps in this process include:

**1. Registration :** an administrative procedure whereby the individual is registered in the PES database so that they are identified as a jobseeker and therefore a possible candidate to whom job offers can be made. The registration form makes it possible to collect civil status information (NAME, first names, date of birth, postal and email addresses and so on) and, above all, information on the professional profile (training courses taken, diplomas, skills and professional experience).



**2. The analysis and diagnosis interview:** which aims to determine the individual's situation with regard to employment; with them, identify the priority areas to be developed and jointly construct a personalized action plan.

**3. Tracking the career path:** If the individual is very autonomous, they will alone organize themselves to implement the necessary actions for their career path. If they are less autonomous, they can ask for a one-off boost from an employment counsellor, or even benefit from individual personalized step-by-step support.



# ▶ 6 Analysis and diagnosis interview

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The stages of the interview

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Techniques and stances for conducting interviews

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Sample questions for the analysis phase

The analysis and diagnosis interview is the core of the PES service offer for a jobseeker. Everyone will benefit, because this is the moment at which the type of service that everyone will be able to benefit from will be determined. This is therefore the heart of the system.

This is often the first individual interview the jobseeker will have with a PES counsellor. Part of the interview will often be devoted to finalising the recording of administrative and profile data, but the main purpose of the interview is to explore and analyse the individual's situation, to diagnose their main need, and then to propose appropriate actions and services. This is a thorough interview that takes time.



## ► The stages of the interview

In order to achieve the objectives of the interview, it is important that the counsellor ensures that the various stages below are followed.

### ► Prepare for the interview.

- Prior to the interview, read the jobseeker's profile (this stage is only possible if the registration stage has already been completed and the file is accessible on the employment service information system).

### ► Opening phase of the interview:

- Welcome the person
- Introduce yourself
- Announce the objective of the interview: "An exchange on your situation and your needs in relation to employment and planning actions useful to your objective"
- Announce the approximate duration of the interview.

### ► Initial expression of expectations :

- When entering the office, the jobseeker usually has one or more expectations. It is important to allow them to express their concerns directly, so that you are listening and not missing the point.
- "What are your main expectations or questions for today's interview?"
- Note the jobseeker's expectations and inform them of the next stages of the interview: "I have taken note of your expectations and questions; before answering them, I propose discussing your situation and your professional profile".

► **Completeness of the application and professional profile**

- If the administrative registration has already been carried out beforehand, this will be a question of taking note of the elements entered and completing or clarifying certain elements, in particular concerning the professional profile.
- Check the jobseeker's contact details with them: address, telephone and email.
- Specify information on training taken and diplomas acquired, activities in previous professional experience, skills mastered and so on.

**Expectations/Needs :**

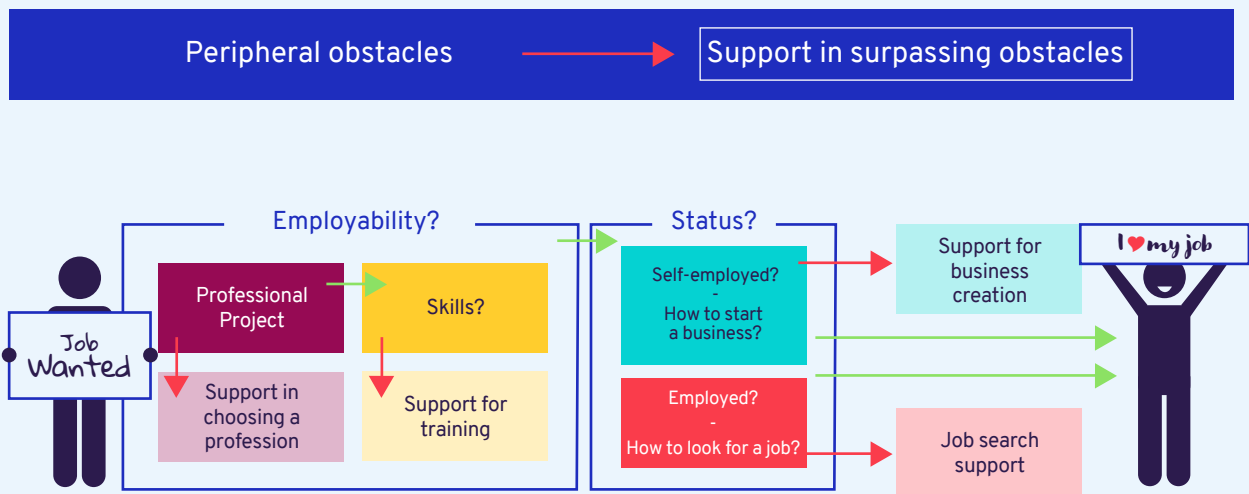
It is important to distinguish between the expectations expressed by the individual and their real needs. In some cases the two will be consistent, but they will often be different, either because the individual is not aware of their situation and their real need or because they choose not to advertise it. The analysis stage will therefore be essential in order to arrive at a shared diagnosis of the situation and the real need.

► **Analysis of skills and knowledge acquired and priority needs :**

- Definition. Analysis = A meticulous, precise study carried out to identify the elements that make up a whole; to explain it and to clarify it.
- The aim is to explore and analyse the individual's situation in relation to the labour market :
  - ✓ Skills and knowledge acquired, points of support
  - ✓ Vulnerabilities and needs
  - ✓ Degree of autonomy
- This analytical work will enable a diagnosis to be made. This analysis must involve the individual, so that the resulting diagnosis is co-constructed and shared. This is very important to ensure that subsequent actions are understood and accepted. Indeed, if the individual does not agree with the conclusions of the diagnosis, it is almost certain that they will not implement the recommended actions.
- The aim of the analysis is to diagnose the individual's priority need. That is to say, the theme that they will have to explore as a priority in order to find a job.
- In the field of professional integration, there is a logical sequence of steps and prerequisites (see diagram) that separate an individual from sustainable, chosen employment:
  - ✓ **The professional project:** has the individual defined the profession that they wish to pursue? Is this occupation realistic and achievable in their labour market? If this is not the case, support in choosing a profession will be the priority service to offer them.
  - ✓ **Skills:** has the individual acquired (through training and/or experience) the theoretical knowledge, know-how, procedural knowledge and interpersonal skills needed to do the job? If so, they will be considered "employable"; in other words, able to work in the chosen profession. If they do not have the required skills, training support should be implemented.
  - ✓ **Under what status does the individual plan to exercise the chosen profession?**
    - **Self-employed status:** the person will have to master the steps of setting up a business and be able to access the necessary funding.
    - **Employee status:** has the person mastered job searching techniques, tools and strategies? Do they know how to use the Internet for their job search? If this is not the case, search support will be needed.
  - ✓ **Peripheral obstacles:** at the same time, the individual needs to remove any obstacles and barriers, often of a social nature (mobility, childcare, health and so on), that might hinder their access to employment.

- ▶ The exploration and analysis phase will therefore aim to identify the individual's situation with regard to these prerequisites in the labour market. This will be achieved through appropriate questioning.
- ▶ See example questions at the end of this chapter.

► **Prerequisites for professional integration and types of PES**



► **Formulation of the shared diagnosis :**

- ▶ The diagnosis specifies the nature of a situation. It is naturally action-oriented. Its purpose is to agree on the priority area of work for the jobseeker, with a view to proposing an action plan.
- ▶ Five priority areas of work are generally used:
  - ✓ Support in choosing a profession
  - ✓ Support for training
  - ✓ Support for business creation
  - ✓ Support for job-seeking
  - ✓ Support in surpassing obstacles. For the latter, implementation will often be subcontracted to partners specialising in social support.
- ▶ This is a logical progression. It is understandable that it is not relevant for the individual to learn how to look for a job if they have not chosen a profession or if they do not yet have the skills required for that profession.
- ▶ The counsellor will have been, carrying out their analysis and interview with the jobseeker on a continuous basis, so that the choice of the priority area of work appears to be obvious to the jobseeker. It is the logic of co-construction that enables us to arrive at a shared and therefore accepted diagnosis.

► **Co-development of the action plan :**

- Definition: “An action plan is a set of actions, tasks or activities to be undertaken in order to achieve a project. This plan is usually set out in a document describing the different steps required to complete the project, the deadlines and who is responsible for each task or activity.
- In our case, the action plan should describe the tasks and activities to be carried out to facilitate the individual's access to employment. This is a logical sequence of actions consistent with the outcome of the diagnosis. It is therefore personalized. It is a kind of “roadmap” for the individual to follow.
- What kind of actions?
  - ✓ Steps to be taken by the individual in autonomy. Example: researching information or using a guide
  - ✓ Actions mobilizing the PES service offer. Example: participation in a workshop or club
  - ✓ Actions involving a third party: meeting with a partner or assessment test in a training organization and so on.
- Points to watch out for :
  - ✓ If the person is far removed from employment, many specific actions will have to be implemented. As much as it is important for the individual to have an overview of the steps ahead, it is not necessary to detail all of the steps in the action plan; this will specify the first actions to be taken, bearing in mind that progress meetings on their implementation may be scheduled between the individual and the counsellor, to consider the next steps (see the chapter on support).
  - ✓ Actions must be organized, ranked and prioritized
  - ✓ Each action must be accompanied by a SMART objective

SMART objective

S M A R T

SPECIFIC  
(PRECISE)



MEASURABLE



ACCESSIBLE



REALISTIC  
FEASIBLE



TEMPORAL



► **Conclude the interview :**

- Formalize the main points of the interview in writing :
  - ✓ Jobseeker's situation
  - ✓ Priority action area resulting from the diagnosis
  - ✓ Next steps in the action plan
- Ensure that the individual understands and adheres to the plan: contractualize.
- Provide them with a copy of the written conclusions.
- Provide any documents and materials that might be useful to them.
- Give them their invitation to any activity foreseen in the action plan.
- Check with the individual that the expectations that they expressed at the beginning of the interview have been met.
- Arrange any follow-up appointment. Depending on the degree of autonomy of the individual and on the resources of the PES, the individual may be offered personalized follow-up on an appropriately frequent basis. Indicate how to contact the counsellor (email/telephone).
- Thank the individual and end the interview.

## ► Techniques and stances for conducting interviews

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Interviews are the counsellor's main working tool; it is therefore essential to master the rules and techniques. Several authors have written on the subject. We will refer here to the work of the American psychologist Carl Rogers, which is very relevant to our field. He has developed a person-centred educational approach (9).

According to Rogers, each supported individual must be considered unique in terms of their interests and values as a person. To a greater or lesser extent they have conscious resources within them that can enable them to react to difficulties and achieve their goals. The role of the counsellor's support is to enable the beneficiary to reflect on their situation in order to access their own resources and initiate a dynamic of change.

To do this, the counsellor must deploy appropriate attitudes, rules and interview techniques :

- **A positive outlook** : respectful and non-judgmental.
- **An attitude of empathy**: making an effort to understand the other person and being receptive to their reactions while remaining emotionally independent.
- **Active and benevolent listening** that allows the beneficiary to feel understood and encouraged to reflect.
- **Semi-directive interviewing**, using the answers to come up with new questions that will give greater insight.
- **Open-ended questions** that encourage expression (as opposed to closed questions that imply a yes or no answer)

- ▶ **Rephrasing** the beneficiary's main **answers** to make sure that the meaning of what they have said is clear.
- ▶ **A level of language adapted** to the individual's register, avoiding professional jargon or acronyms.
- ▶ **"Listen" to the** recipient's **non-verbal language** – respect silences – avoid interrupting.
- ▶ **Look them in the** eye and show that you are paying attention.
- ▶ **Ensure confidentiality:** do not disclose any personal information without the consent of the beneficiary.
- ▶ **Remain impartial:** do not make personal judgments about their development project.
- ▶ **Respect the individual's initiative:** Preserve the beneficiary's free choice without imposing a particular strategy.

## ▶ Sample questions for the analysis phase

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Some PES use self-diagnosis questionnaires that are offered to the jobseeker at the time of registration so that they can prepare for their meeting with the counsellor, allowing the jobseeker to start thinking about the topics to be discussed during the interview. If completed, these materials will be useful to the counsellor, who will follow up with additional questions to gain more insight.

As indicated in the “pre-requisites for professional integration” diagram, the questioning in the analysis phase will be aimed at identifying the jobseeker’s main needs with regard to the themes already presented:

- ▶ The professional project
- ▶ The skills
- ▶ The choice of status: self-employed or employee
- ▶ The ability to conduct their own job search (mastery of job search techniques and digital autonomy)
- ▶ Peripheral obstacles

Here are some suggested questions, to be adapted and completed according to the individual, their answers and the context :

### Questions on the professional project :

- ✓ Have you ever worked?
- ✓ What job did you do?
- ✓ Would you like to continue in this profession?
- ✓ Do you know which profession you would like to pursue first?
- ✓ Do you know how to choose a future profession?
- ✓ Do you know where to find information on professions?
- ✓ Do you need support to develop your career plan?
- ✓ Do you think your career plan is specific enough?
- ✓ Do you think that your career plan is feasible in terms of the job market in your job-seeking area?

### Questions on skills :

- ✓ Do you think you will be immediately operational in this profession?
- ✓ What do you know how to do? What are your strengths?
- ✓ Do you think you need training to carry out your project? In what area? In which skills?
- ✓ Have you identified training courses and organizations to enable you to complete your skills?
- ✓ Do you need support to build your training pathway?

### Questions on the choice of status

- ✓ Would you like to work in this profession as an employee or as a self-employed person in your own company?

## Optional questions on starting a business

- ✓ Have you defined your start-up project precisely?
- ✓ Are you familiar with the steps and procedures involved in starting up a business?
- ✓ Have you carried out a market study and drawn up a business plan?
- ✓ Have you found the funding?
- ✓ Do you think you need support to prepare your start-up project?
- ✓ Do you know people who can support/guide you through the implementation of your project?

## Optional questions on job seeking

- ✓ Do you know the situation in the labour market for your profession in your geographical area?
- ✓ Do you already have contacts with future employers?
- ✓ Do you know how to target companies to be contacted?
- ✓ Do you know how to organize your job search?
- ✓ Have you made a CV? If so, let's look at it together
- ✓ Do you know how to adapt a CV for each application?
- ✓ Do you know how to write a cover letter or spontaneous application?
- ✓ Do you know how to use the Internet and social networks for your job search?
- ✓ Do you know how to highlight your skills and assets during a job interview?

## Questions on peripheral obstacles

- ✓ Do you think you have any personal constraints to take into account in your job search?
- ✓ What kind of constraints?
- ✓ How do you get around? Do you have a means of transport?
- ✓ How far from home can you accept a job?
- ✓ Do you have access to a computer or telephone to use the Internet for your business?
- ✓ Do you think you need to improve your language skills (written/spoken)?
- ✓ Do you have a childminding solution while you are working?
- ✓ Is there anything about your health that you think is relevant to your ability to job hunt and work?
- ✓ Can you think of any other constraints: housing, family, administrative or financial, that it would be useful to take into account?
- ✓ Do you need support to deal with these difficulties?

The counsellor will have to choose the most relevant questions and rephrase them to suit the vocabulary and language level of the person being counselled.



# 7 Personalized support



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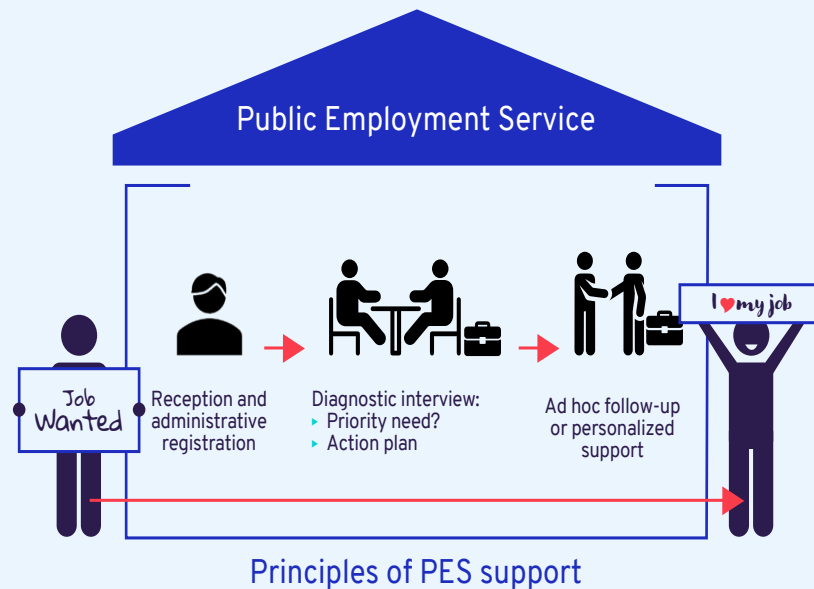
What is the target audience?

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Styles of support

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Stages of personalized support  
towards employment



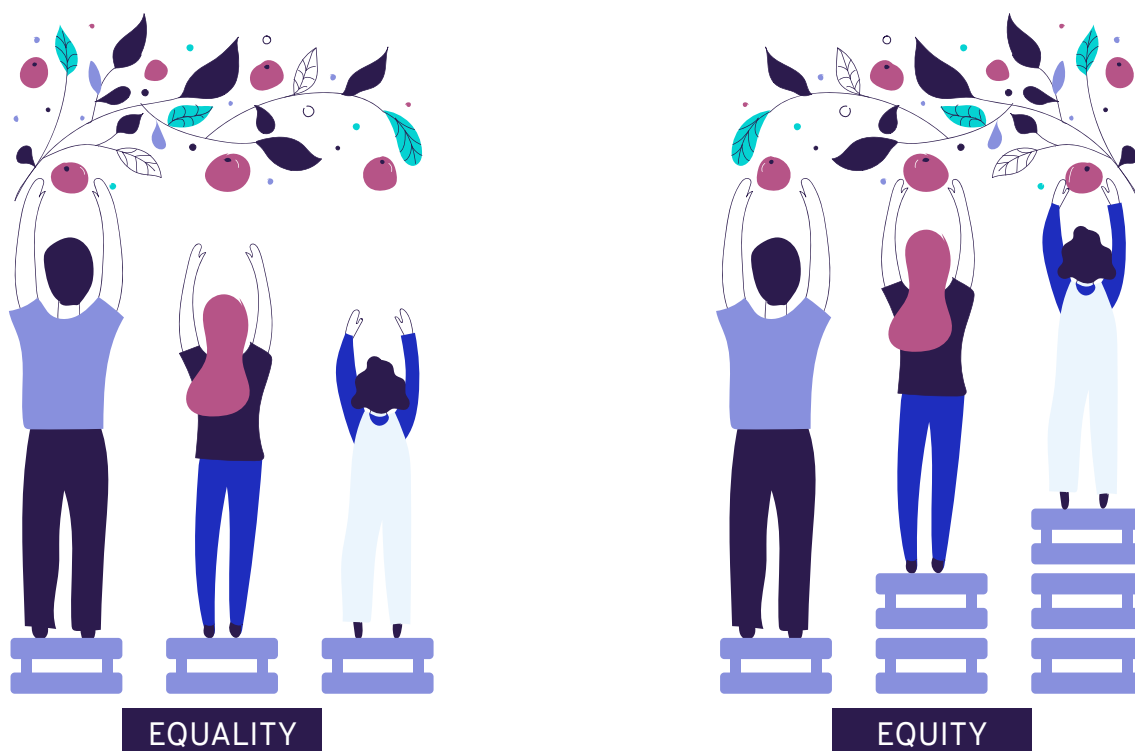
During the analysis and diagnosis interview, the counsellor was able to offer to set up a personalized support programme for the individual. What is it about?

This support is a “service +” implemented by some PES. Not everyone can afford it, especially in a context of mass unemployment. If the counsellor and the jobseeker have defined a tailor-made action plan during the first interview, the important thing is to implement this sequence of actions. However, some individuals will have difficulty in carrying out these procedures on their own and may fall into long-term unemployment. In order to avoid this risk, many PES have been developing this new level of service for several years: personalized support.

The aim is to provide the individual with a contact person who will follow them or her for several weeks or months, in the form of regular face-to-face meetings but also remote contacts (telephone, video, email and so on) in order to guide and support them through the processes set out in the action plan. They will also support them in identifying further processes that will be necessary in order for their situation to advance.

## ► Which public should be supported first?

In line with ILO Convention No. 88 (already mentioned above), the PES were developed to ensure equal access to the “public service”. Their priority, at the time of their creation, was to deploy a network of local agencies throughout a country’s national territory, that were capable of providing the same range of services to all. For those PES that have achieved this goal, the strategy has subsequently shifted from equality (the same service for all) to equity (the best service for everyone).



The needs of individuals are indeed different and PES must have the capacity to “do more for those who need it most”. Personal support will usually be offered to the least independent people.

In the health sector, autonomy is defined as “a person’s ability to carry out the main activities of daily life without assistance, whether physical, mental, social or economic, and to adapt to their environment” (10).

In the field of professional integration, autonomy is generally considered to be a jobseeker’s ability to conduct an effective job search without the help of a counsellor.

This is how Pôle emploi (the French PES) presents autonomy:



## UNDERSTANDING AUTONOMY FOR PÔLE EMPLOI

Being autonomous in your job search or in implementing your project means not only knowing how to take steps alone, but also to know how to make informed decisions and implement effective actions; this in turn means:

- ▶ Knowing oneself well
- ▶ Have a good perception of your situation in relation to your environment
- ▶ Set consistent goals
- ▶ Know how to mobilize resources wisely to achieve these objectives

### ✓ To be autonomous is...

- ▶ ... **unique to each individual**
- ▶ ... **relative**: one can be autonomous in one or more areas and not in others
- ▶ ... **dynamic**: it is constructed: "to gain autonomy"

### ✗ It is not...

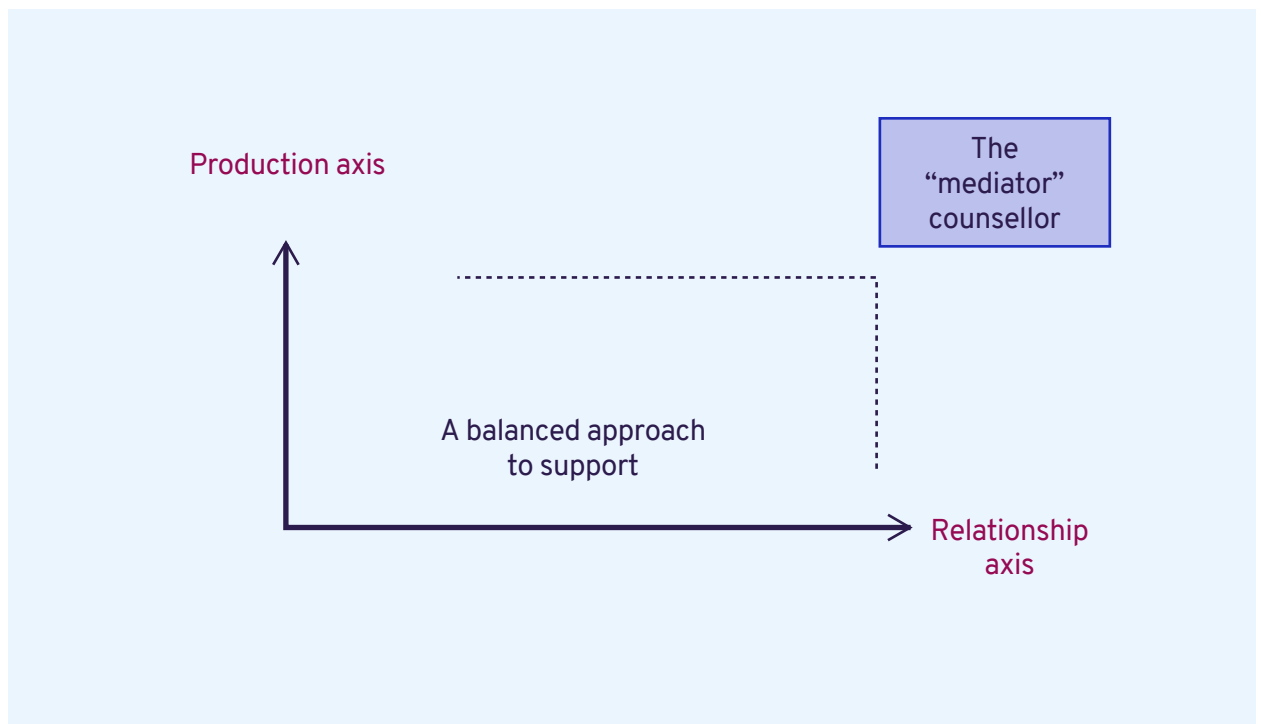
- ▶ ... **determined** according to a category: age, disability, level of qualification and so on.
- ▶ ... **absolute**: the degree of autonomy is different in different areas and contexts
- ▶ ... **fixed**: it is not a definitive state: "we are not either autonomous or not autonomous, once and for all"

## ▶ Styles of support

The counsellor will offer support to the least autonomous people to guide them through the sequence of steps in the action plan and achieve their successful professional integration. But how should this support be successfully provided?

According to Dominique Clavier, an occupational psychologist and clinical psychologist (11), ideally the counsellor's intervention will balance two aspects :

- ▶ **The production axis**, which concerns the achievement of objectives by mobilizing tools, methods and so on.
- ▶ **The relationship axis**, which corresponds to the way in which the counsellor manages their connections with the individual and involves them in achieving their targeted objectives, with a view to personal development.



Through the prism of caricature, one could imagine some counsellors, obsessed with the objective of integration, deploying “instrumentalist” support: doing things in the place of the individual without leaving them any place for reflecting upon and implementing actions. On the other hand, other counsellors will focus exclusively on creating a relationship of trust with the individual, promoting their well-being and development, but without paying attention to the deadlines for the action plan or proposing tools and methods.

In everyday life, “supporting” means “being with” and “going together towards”. It means guiding, supporting and sustaining, while respecting the individual and their choices. It is not a question of “doing it for” the persons being supported or obliging them to act in a certain way, but rather of giving them support and advice, in a personalized manner when necessary, in constructing and managing their pathway.

The ideal stance is that of the “mediator” counsellor, who provides their support by working on both the production aspect and on the beneficiary’s personal development, establishing links between the two. They thus reinforce the realism of the project, its roots and its viability, taking into account their beneficiary’s internal dynamics as the support is provided.

The aim of the support is not only to solve a specific problem of access to the labour market, it is also intended to develop the individual’s autonomy, so that they are more at ease in the environment around them and able to manage the other professional transitions that they are likely to face during their career.

## ► Stages of personalized support towards employment

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The personalized support that the individual will receive will not necessarily be implemented by the counsellor who carried out the initial analysis and diagnosis interview; it will more often be carried out either by another PES counsellor, or by an external subcontractor or a PES partner, often specialising in a particular type of public or support theme. This support should therefore be seen as a new stage in the jobseeker's journey, bringing together two actors who do not yet know each other: the jobseeker and their "contact person" in charge of providing the support over time.

Here are some key steps to consider when providing personalized support towards employment. These steps will be spread over a series of personal interviews.

### 1. Scoping phase:

- **Welcome, introductions:** Establish a calm climate that is conducive to the process
- **Explanation of the mechanism:** "We are here to facilitate your access to employment.."
- **The procedures:** Clearly explain the support and its concrete procedures.
- **Objective:** The "personalized support towards employment" service that starts for the person is the result of a "prescription" made during the analysis and diagnosis interview. It is essential, right from the framing phase, to ensure that the person still shares the objective that has been determined:
  - ✓ Support in choosing a profession
  - ✓ Support for training (can be coupled with the above)
  - ✓ Support for business creation
  - ✓ Support for job-seeking
  - ✓ Support in surpassing peripheral obstacles
- **Duration.** It is very important to make this point clear from the beginning:
  - ✓ either the duration of the support is variable and stops once the objective has been reached, for example: the subject starts training or is recruited into a stable job;
  - ✓ or the support is planned for a fixed period (for example three months), during which the actions will aim to develop the person's autonomy to carry out their job searches and pursue them on their own after the support ends.
- **Establishment of reciprocal roles:** What the person can expect from their contact person and what is expected of them. They must understand that they will have to mobilize themselves and be proactive in their own project. Not to expect everything from the contact person, who will not do it for them.
- **Presentation of the "rules of the game":** Obtaining a commitment from the person to respect the rules of correct operation: presenteeism, punctuality, involvement in the process, transparency, reporting on actions performed, reciprocal information and so on. The supporting contact person

also commits themselves, particularly to the ethical aspect: confidentiality, impartiality, benevolence and so on.

- ▶ **Membership:** Once the framework has been explained and the person has had the opportunity to ask clarifying questions, it is necessary to ensure that they agree with the approach. Some schemes will provide for the signing of a commitment contract by both parties to the support process (jobseeker and contact person), a document setting out in writing the main elements outlined above.

## 2. Discovery phase:

- ▶ **Multidimensional portrait:** getting the person to present themselves in depth. Allow them time to express everything they want, so that the counsellor can understand their profile and their issues. A questioning and listening phase that should enable the person to formulate their expectations and shortcomings in their own words, but also to begin to identify their resources, networks, points of support, challenges and so on.
- ▶ **Motivation/empowerment:** Explain the method that will be used in the subsequent steps and show the person that they will be the main actor in the process. They will be the pilot of their professional future

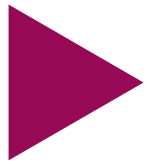
**The following phases of the support will be closely linked to the objective pursued by the individual. Thus, in the following two chapters, we present the methodology for:**

- ✓ **Supporting the professional project: choice of a profession and training**
- ✓ **Support with jobseeking**

## 3. Cross-cutting instructions:

- ▶ Following the support, whatever the objective pursued, the contact person will oversee the following cross-cutting elements:
- ▶ Co-writing and feeding into the roadmap at the end of each interview so that the person clearly identifies the actions to be taken between then and the next meeting
- ▶ At the beginning of each new interview, following up on the actions taken and their results
- ▶ Identifying any new contextual elements, obstacles or levers throughout the process
- ▶ Helping the person to develop their network and activate it in the context of their job search
- ▶ Helping the person to anticipate possible future problems in order to reduce their potential impact on the person and their project
- ▶ Supporting the person through difficult phases to help them cope with change
- ▶ Maintaining the person's motivation despite the failure of an action or process
- ▶ Continuously ensure that the individual is adhering to the approach, understands it, can navigate it and is gradually developing autonomy.
- ▶ Once the deadline has been reached, take stock of the support period, identify the achievements, prospects and actions to be taken, and close the process.





## 8

## Support in choosing a profession

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Knowing myself better

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Discovering professions

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Choosing my future profession

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Building my strategy

The methodology described in this chapter is based on the practical guide already published by the ILO entitled “How to choose my future profession?”

[https://www.ilo.org/global/topics/youth-employment/publications/WCMS\\_800646/lang--en/index.htm](https://www.ilo.org/global/topics/youth-employment/publications/WCMS_800646/lang--en/index.htm)



This guide for jobseekers will also be your support tool. Download it for free in PDF format from the ILO website. In it, you will find details of the exercises listed below. You can also give a copy to the jobseeker you are accompanying, to use as an exercise book.

Choosing a profession is one of the first stages in a young adolescent's confrontation with the world of adult life. Depending on the education system, the question of career guidance will arise at different times during their schooling, in order to define an appropriate educational curriculum for the project. However, it would be wrong to think that choosing a profession is a once-in-a-lifetime decision.

With the accelerated changes in the labour market, everyone has to update or change their career plans several times during their career. Each individual must therefore acquire the ability to get their bearings throughout life in order to be better able to bounce back from the obstacles they encounter. One of the counsellor's ambitions during the career guidance will be to develop the jobseeker's autonomy so that they become the pilot of their own career and not a mere passenger.

The guidance methodology proposed in this guide is loosely based on a number of approaches, including the vocational and personal development activation method (ADVP). It is a career and personal orientation approach originating in Quebec, created in 1974 by Denis Pelletier, Charles Bujold and Gilles Noiseux.

Our approach is suitable for everyone, regardless of their age or level of qualification. It is person-centred. It proposes that the individual think about their project for themselves and by themselves. It considers that each individual, given the appropriate support, is capable of self-determination and of finding the answers to their questions within themselves.

The method is based on practical exercises organized around four chronological stages:

- **Knowing myself better:** The individual reflects on their interests, expectations, skills, values, constraints, and so on.
- **Discovering professions:** The individual will use several sources to list ideas of professions, without restriction, before comparing them with their profile, to arrive at a shortlist.
- **Choosing my future profession:** The individual is guided to research and investigate each of the professions on their list, which will enable them to make a choice.
- **Building my strategy:** This last stage allows the individual to develop a coherent action plan, which may include a training pathway to develop their skills.



## ► **Knowing myself better** (pages 2 to 6 of the guide)

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The individual reflects on their skills, areas of interest, expectations, values, constraints and so on; they thus sketch out their professional portrait. As a supporting counsellor, we propose that you adopt the following work sequences:

### **Identifying skills:**

- Explain the concept of skills: the capacity to perform a manual or mental activity acquired through learning and practice. The term “skills” is a general term used to refer to the knowledge, know-how and experience needed to perform a specific task or job. Thus, in our daily professional activity, we mobilize skills. Some are cross-cutting and apply to a number of professions or sectors; others are very specific.
- Give examples and get the person to list as many skills as possible that they have been able to use in their personal and professional life, some of which will be transferable to their future profession.
- Explain the value of cross-cutting and behavioural skills, which are now favoured by employers. A list with definitions will help the person being supported to identify those that they have mastered.

### **What is important for me:**

- Get the person to describe their ideal working environment. This involves identifying preferences in terms of values, interests, environment and working conditions. An indicative, non-exhaustive list is proposed to facilitate reflection.
- After listing, the person should be led to prioritize.

## My constraints:

- This stage of reflection is often overlooked in career guidance processes. However, it is essential for a choice of profession that is truly adapted to the individual. We all have constraints that block us to a greater or lesser degree, the most common of which are identified in a table divided into four families: mobility; health; family; working hours and days.

**NB Reflection work takes time. It cannot be carried out during the support sessions. It will be done by the person during the time between sessions, between two sessions.**

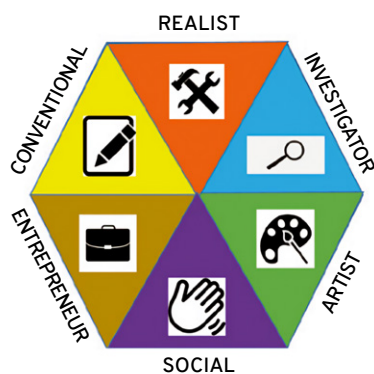
| Working hours and days                                                                | Mobility – possibility of moving house                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working nights                              | <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working in my neighbourhood                                                                     |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working evenings                            | <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working in my whole city                                                                        |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working daytime hours                       | <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working in a place that is more than one hour away from my home                                 |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working in a team (3 x 8) with team changes | <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working away from home without coming home every night                                          |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working every Saturday                      | <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage moving house to take a job                                                                      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working every Sunday                        | <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working in another country                                                                      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working one weekend in two                  | <input type="checkbox"/> I have no means of transport (personal or public)                                                                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't imagine working every weekend                        | <input type="checkbox"/> I don't have a driving licence                                                                                   |
| Health and working posture:                                                           | Family – children and dependants                                                                                                          |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working on my feet all day                  | <input type="checkbox"/> I have no way of getting my children to school when I'm at work                                                  |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working on my feet for a number of hours    | <input type="checkbox"/> I don't have a solution for childminding when I'm at work                                                        |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working sitting down all day                | <input type="checkbox"/> If I'm caring for a dependent person at home (elderly or disabled), I have nobody to replace me when I'm at work |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working sitting for a number of hours       |                                                                                                                                           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working performing repetitive motions       |                                                                                                                                           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working on a screen                         |                                                                                                                                           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working carrying heavy loads                |                                                                                                                                           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working at height                           |                                                                                                                                           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> I can't envisage working outside, in the cold or in the heat |                                                                                                                                           |

## ► Discovering professions (pages 7 to 12 of the guide)

The individual will use several sources to list ideas of professions, without restriction, before comparing them with their profile, to arrive at a shortlist. In addition to the exercises in the guide, online questionnaires and placement tests are also available on many websites. These can be used to suggest ideas of professions and can complement this chapter well; however, it is advisable to prioritize serious and proven sites, as the best can be found alongside the worst on the Internet.

## List ideas of professions:

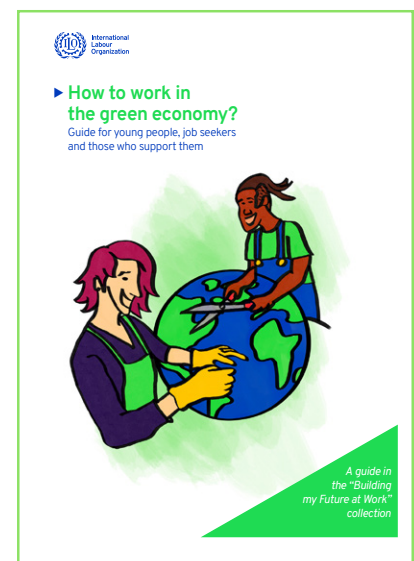
- During the previous phase on the professional portrait, ideas for a profession started to germinate in the mind of the person being supported. In this new sequence, encourage the person to list all of the ideas for professions that come to mind, without restraint or limitation.
- They should draw inspiration from their professional portrait, but also from the list of 32 fields of economic activity that may be found in the guide. We generally find that individuals, especially young people, know very little about different professions. Their list is limited to the professions of their relatives and friends and those often mentioned in the media and on social networks. The list is usually very short. In this listing phase, it is therefore essential to open up horizons by leading the individual to discover new sectors of activity and professions.



- The psychologist Jean HOLLAND has shown that each individual has dominant interests linked to their personality. He identified six main types of professional interests that cover all existing professions. The table and definitions provided on page 10 of the guide allow you to help the person being supported to position themselves and list additional ideas for professions. Many personality tests on the Internet also refer to the HOLLAND typologies.

## Discovering the green economy

- At a time when they have to choose their professional future, many young people at the end of their schooling (or adults) who are sensitive to global issues would like their future profession to be consistent with their convictions and to contribute to flattening the carbon curve. However, for non-specialists, the green economy is still very unclear. Which professions should one lean towards? What skills should one acquire? To support them, the ILO has published a specific guide: "How to work in the green economy?". This offers lists of professions that will complement the reflection work previously described.
- The guide can be downloaded free of charge from the ILO website: [https://www.ilo.org/global/topics/youth-employment/publications/WCMS\\_856666/lang--en/index.htm](https://www.ilo.org/global/topics/youth-employment/publications/WCMS_856666/lang--en/index.htm)



## Mobilizing their network:

For each discovery of professions exercise, encourage the individual to mobilize their network (family, friends, former colleagues and so on). This instruction is valid for all phases of the employment support process and has only advantages:

- It breaks the isolation that is common among jobseekers and always negative
- It enables the individual to receive external advice on their assets, skills and limitations and, above all, suggestions on ideas for professions or even employment offers.

## Sort and prioritize:

You have encouraged the individual to list all of the occupations that might attract their attention, without any limits. The next stage is to compare this long list with the professional portrait that they established in the previous step. Are these jobs compatible with their preferences, their skills (even if they can acquire new ones) and their constraints? From the remaining professions, have them rank their top five.

## ► Choosing my future profession (pages 13–16 of the guide)

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All professions have positive and negative aspects. From the outside, we may tend to idealize them or, reversely, see their adverse aspects only. We have all witnessed young apprentices or students dropping out of their vocational training after a few months, belatedly realising that the profession that they are learning is not suitable for them. It is therefore essential, during the orientation phase, to investigate each profession before making an informed choice.

Your role as a supporting counsellor is to explain the importance of this stage and to guide the processes to be followed. However, one should not “do it for them”. It is important that the individual take these steps on their own, in order to derive maximum benefit. Two methods are recommended: documentary research and investigations with professionals.

## Documentary research:

The Internet is an inexhaustible source of easily findable fact sheets, in the main languages, on most professions and professional sectors. As an employment professional, you know the main professional sites and directories to counsel the person you are supporting. You will encourage them to look for information on the prerequisites for the job, the skills, training and qualifications, the activities carried out, working conditions, salaries, recruitment methods, the current situation of the labour market and so on.

For each of the top five occupations, you will ask the person you are supporting to write a sheet containing this information. They will supplement this with the results of the investigations.

## Investigations with professionals

This is the most effective way to be confronted with the realities of a profession. Often the person being supported will “resist” carrying out these investigations, fearing that they will disturb a professional and that they will be badly received. On the contrary, as long as you don't take up too much of their time, professionals love talking about their work and are always very good at giving advice.

### What questions should I ask the professional that I meet?

- ✓ Can you describe a working day for me? What are your main activities?
- ✓ Your working conditions? (Routines, schedules and so on.)
- ✓ What do you like best about your work?
- ✓ What do you like least?
- ✓ What skills and knowledge are needed for this profession?
- ✓ What advice would you give to someone who wants to go into this profession today?
- ✓ Could you direct me to colleagues who would also be willing to answer my questions?

### Time to decide

Your role here is to help the person to use the decision support grid on page 16 to compare the information gathered with their professional profile. It is only a facilitation tool. Reflection can take time and maturity. This decision should not be rushed as it will commit the individual for years to come.

In addition to the research already carried out, if the possibility exists in the service offer of your PES, it may be relevant to organize a work placement in a company, in order to discover the future profession.

| Is this job compatible with: YES/NO                                     | M1 | M2 | M3 | M4 | M5 |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|----|----|----|----|
| Job title                                                               |    |    |    |    |    |
| My level of education. Do I have a sufficient level to join the course? |    |    |    |    |    |
| My knowledge and skills?                                                |    |    |    |    |    |
| My values:..                                                            |    |    |    |    |    |
| My interests:..                                                         |    |    |    |    |    |
| My preferences:..                                                       |    |    |    |    |    |
| My constraints:..                                                       |    |    |    |    |    |
| The labour market for this trade is: good/average/difficult             |    |    |    |    |    |
| Average salary for this job                                             |    |    |    |    |    |
| My final ranking                                                        |    |    |    |    |    |

## ► Building my strategy (pages 17–20 of the guide)

After having reflected in depth on their expectations and profile and having discovered and investigated professions, the person you are supporting has just compared the elements collected to identify the job that will best suit them. This choice of profession becomes their professional project.

The last stage of the support process is intended to prepare the strategy for making the project a reality. That is, to help the person identify the actions to be taken in order to be able to exercise the chosen profession in the more or less near future.

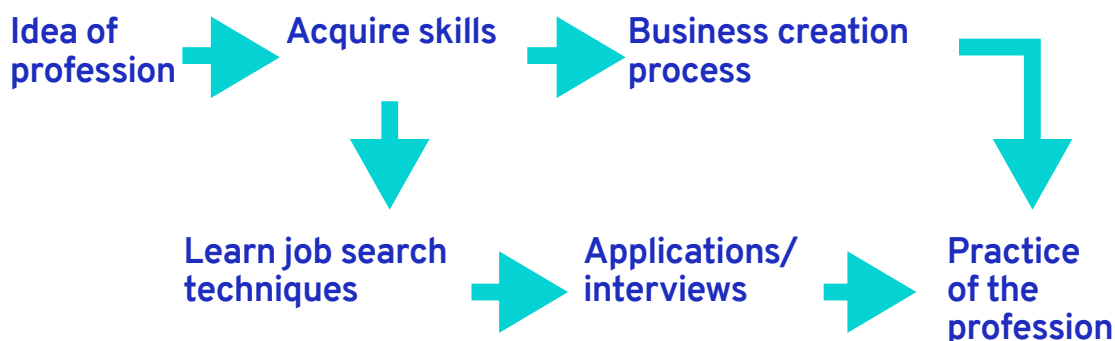
### Choice of status

There are two ways to practise a profession: either as an employee or by setting up your own business as an entrepreneur. As a counsellor in an employment service, you have to get the individual to ask themselves the question. If they are considering the second option, it would be appropriate to direct them to information or awareness-raising sessions on business creation, which would allow them to explore this avenue and verify their ability to create a viable business. If they are considering employee status, they will have to learn how to conduct a job search, which is the subject of our next chapter.

In both cases, it will be essential for them to ask themselves about skills. Have they already mastered the essential skills of their chosen profession? If this is not the case, you can help them to draw up their training plan, based on the table on page 20.

### Formalization of the action plan

The writing of the action plan generally coincides with the end of support for the professional project.



It is therefore an opportunity to summarize the achievements of the process while informing the individual about the stages ahead that will make the project a reality. The table provided in the guide can help with this formalization. It will probably be necessary to support the individual regarding how to use it.

Finally, even if the support ends, it is important that the individual should be able to identify the resources that they can mobilize during the next stages and does not feel weak in implementing their project.

| Actions                                                                    | Deadline | With whom, where, how? | Archived |                   |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|------------------------|----------|-------------------|
|                                                                            |          |                        | Y/N      | Corrective Action |
| Present my project to my friends and family                                |          |                        |          |                   |
| Present my project to people and organizations who can counsel and help me |          |                        |          |                   |
| Identify the skills that I am missing                                      |          |                        |          |                   |
| Build my training project (*advice on next page)                           |          |                        |          |                   |
| Find funding for my training                                               |          |                        |          |                   |
| Follow my training and obtain my diploma                                   |          |                        |          |                   |
| Prepare an appropriate CV for my new job                                   |          |                        |          |                   |
| Target companies and establish my job search strategy                      |          |                        |          |                   |
| Remove any obstacles                                                       |          |                        |          |                   |
| Make unsolicited applications                                              |          |                        |          |                   |
| Use social networks                                                        |          |                        |          |                   |
| Prepare for job interviews                                                 |          |                        |          |                   |
| Prepare my arrival in the company and my first days in my new position     |          |                        |          |                   |

## ► Be trained in project support

Guiding an individual in choosing their future profession requires skills. This guide provides you with basic methodology that will need to be reinforced by appropriate training, peer coaching and practice. When the activity of the counsellor involves the use of psychotechnical tests, it is essential to have completed a training course in occupational psychology. In many countries, the profession of guidance counsellor is regulated.



# 9 Support with jobseeking

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My project – my profile

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Tools and techniques for jobseeking

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Understanding and exploiting the labour market

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Using the Internet in your job search

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Developing a research strategy

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Integrating into the company

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As an employment counsellor, your daily work will consist in providing support and guidance on job search techniques, tools and strategies. This is likely to be the main expectation of the people you interview. You must therefore acquire real expertise and fluency in these subjects.

The use of job search tools is almost obligatory for any adult seeking paid employment. This often takes the form of a CV to apply in response to published vacancies, or the submission of unsolicited applications. But few jobseekers build a real structured job search strategy that could greatly increase the effectiveness of their actions. The role of the employment counsellor is therefore to guide them in learning how to search effectively for a job.

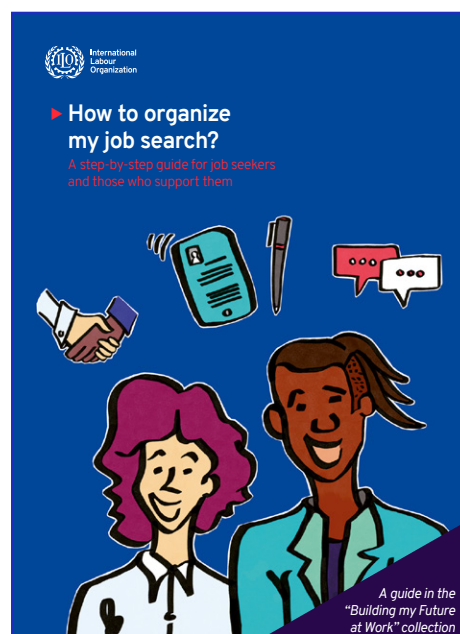
On a day-to-day basis, you will need to be able to give occasional advice on the presentation of a CV, the wording of a letter, the use of an online job site and so on, but you will also need to be able to support a jobseeker in learning and implementing a complete job search process. You will have to guide your interviewee to prepare their arguments, build their tools, understand the job market, use the Internet and develop an effective search strategy that is suitable for their objective.

The methodology described in this chapter is based on the practical guide already published by the ILO entitled “How to organize my job search?”

[https://www.ilo.org/global/topics/youth-employment/publications/WCMS\\_829530/lang--en/index.htm](https://www.ilo.org/global/topics/youth-employment/publications/WCMS_829530/lang--en/index.htm)

This guide for jobseekers will also be your support tool. Download it for free in PDF format from the ILO website. In it, you will find details of the exercises listed below. You can also give a copy to the jobseeker you are accompanying, to use as an exercise book.

The shelves of bookshops and specialized websites are full of books and advice on how to write a CV, an application letter or prepare for a job interview, but you will rarely find a complete search process. This guide provides a structured and comprehensive method for approaching the labour market effectively. It is freely inspired by the work of Arthur F. MILLS in Canada, as well as Dominique CLAVIER, Daniel POROT and Josette LAYEC in France.



## ► My project - my profile (pages 1 to 4 of the guide)

In the first interview with the jobseeker you should first make sure that they are ready to look for a job. That is, they have a clear career plan and are immediately employable in this profession. If not, they will have to reflect on their project or take training.

Often, the jobseeker will want to go straight into constructing a CV or application letter. Before doing so, it is important that they take time to sketch out their own professional portrait and prepare content that can be used in their tools.

### Clarify the elements of my profile:

Guide the jobseeker to list, describe and write all the “bricks” making up their profile (see categories in the “wall” below). This will enable them to prepare a “bank of arguments” that can be used at each

stage of the process. To convince an employer, you must first of all identify what you can offer and be prepared to argue on your own profile.

|                         |                                 |                      |                      |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
| Professional experience | Qualities                       | Results              | Languages            |
| Skills                  | Initial training                | Software             | Publications         |
| Permits                 | Personal and social experiences | Continuing education | Interpersonal skills |
| Knowledge               | Achievements                    | Diplomas             | Leisure ...          |

You will then lead the jobseeker to question their motivation. It is important that they are clear about their expectations in their job search, in order to target companies, prioritize job offers and prepare for interviews. A table is provided in the guide to help them identify their main expectations.

## ► Job search tools and techniques (pages 5-15 of the guide)

This is often “the tip of the iceberg”. Indeed, the jobseeker tends to think that preparing a CV, or even an application letter, is enough to conduct a successful search. Your role will be to assist in the preparation of these tools, while guiding them on how to use them effectively, through the following chapters.

### The CV and cover letter

Different countries have different job search practices and tools. You will therefore need to become an expert on the practices in your country, in order to best support jobseekers.

In the guide you can read all of the tips and rules to follow when preparing a CV or a cover letter. Here we will focus on a few messages that you should take the time to explain to the jobseeker:

- ✓ **The CV is a communication** medium that aims to capture the recruiter's attention in order to make them want to meet the person for an interview. Knowing that a recruiter spends between 30 seconds and 2 minutes reading a CV, they must easily find the information that makes them think that the application is worthy of interest, in view of the position to be filled.
- ✓ **1 post = 1 CV:** You should explain to the jobseeker that they cannot use the same CV for each application. Each time they apply for a job, they should create a new CV adapted to the profile of the position to be filled. This is the “mirror application” method. It is a matter of identifying the employer's specific expectations in the job offer and then constructing a tailor-made CV,

highlighting the elements of the profile and experience that best correspond. To do this, they will draw upon the “bank of arguments” that they prepared earlier.

- ✓ **Skills:** Given the rapid evolution of professions, most employers are more interested in skills than in diplomas. This has an impact on the form and content of the CV. These days it is more important to highlight the skills acquired and applied during the various professional experiences, giving concrete and convincing data if possible: achievements, results and so on.
- ✓ **The cover letter:** this complements the CV to help convince the recruiter to shortlist the application for an interview. It should not be duplicated. First of all, the candidate must show that they know the company, its activity, its projects and so on, and that they have understood the employer’s needs regarding the position to be filled. Then they will present the most relevant elements of their profile.

## Preparing for the interview

As a counsellor, you will sometimes be contacted in a hurry by a jobseeker whom you are supporting, informing you that they have just been called for a first job interview and asking for your advice. Ideally, you should have been able to anticipate this situation. It is indeed important that the candidate understands the rules of a recruitment interview, can prepare the main questions (see list in the guide) and ideally role play. As a counsellor, you can organize regular mock interview exercises with the people you support, alternating between the roles of recruiter and candidate.

## Some tips for the candidate:



- ▶ Understand the position to be filled:
  - ▶ Before sending your application (CV+letter), analyse the job offer. Take it back and deepen your understanding of the offer.
  - ▶ Make sure you can identify the recruiter’s expectations
  - ▶ Be prepared to show the recruiter that you understand the position to be filled.
- ▶ Find out more about the company:
  - ▶ Sources: Internet, press, company employees and so on
  - ▶ In particular, be sure to explore the company’s website and social networks (LinkedIn, Viadeo, Facebook and Twitter)
- ▶ The history of the company, the name of the director, activities, products, news, projects and so on.
- ▶ Prepare questions to ask about the company at the end of the interview.
- ▶ Prepare your arguments
  - ▶ Reread the CV that you sent
  - ▶ For each of the employer’s expectations, prepare one or more answers based on your experience, with arguments, figures, results and so on.
- ▶ Practise your interview:

- ▶ hold several mock interviews with a friend or family member
- ▶ Some websites also offer interactive simulators
- ▶ Locate the locations:
  - ▶ A few days before, make the journey and go to the site. This will prevent you from getting lost or being late on the day of the appointment. Otherwise, plan your route in advance.
  - ▶ If the interview is by video, test the connection tool in advance
- ▶ On the day of the interview:
  - ▶ Clothing: clean, appropriate for the profession and the working environment
  - ▶ Make a good impression from the moment you arrive at the reception desk
  - ▶ From the start of the interview, be cordial, smiling, polite, attentive and a good listener.
  - ▶ The recruiter's judgement is often formed in the first few minutes of the interview

## ▶ Understanding and exploiting the labour market

(pages 17-19 of the guide)

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Depending on the country, only 10 to 40 per cent of recruitments are published as job advertisements. This may be through the Public Employment Service, private employment or temp agencies, the press, specialized websites or social networks. This is the so-called "open market"; in other words, the recruitment opportunities are visible to all. On the other hand, the "hidden market" includes all recruitments that are made without the employer publishing a job offer. Positions are filled either through networking or through unsolicited applications.

It is important to understand that if an employer does not advertise their need for recruitment by advertising a job offer, it is usually because they do not need to. Indeed, as soon as a position is available in a company or organization (creation or resignation), this information will quickly become known to its staff, its suppliers and its customers. It will be relayed through various networks: employees, family, friends and so on. It is likely that profiles will thus be offered directly to the recruiter by their own employees or their own network. Moreover, the company director regularly receives unsolicited applications, and it is often sufficient to contact these people to find the right candidate. It is therefore only if no direct application satisfies them that the recruiter will feel the need to advertise a job. This is often the case for highly qualified positions for which profiles are scarce on the labour market.

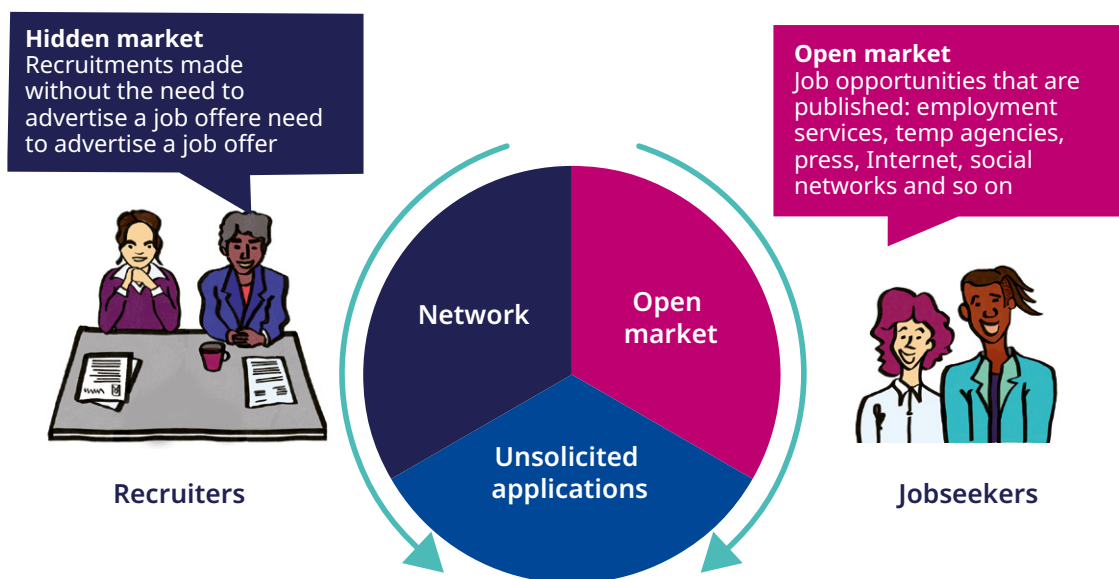
Jobseekers generally limit themselves to exploiting the open market (and often not exhaustively). By doing so, they depriving themselves of many employment opportunities. As an employment counsellor, you should help them understand how the labour market works and encourage them to make the most of all its facets: unsolicited applications, information monitoring, networking and so on.

## ► Using the Internet in your job search (pages 21–28 of the guide)

The Internet has profoundly transformed relationships in the world of work, jobseeking and recruitment practices. The ease of access to information, the instantaneous dissemination of needs and the immediacy of contacts have accelerated certain recruitment processes and, above all, widened the possibilities of making contact; in particular, overcoming geographical barriers.

The Internet offers three essential functionalities that must be used by jobseekers if they do not want to risk cutting themselves off from many opportunities:

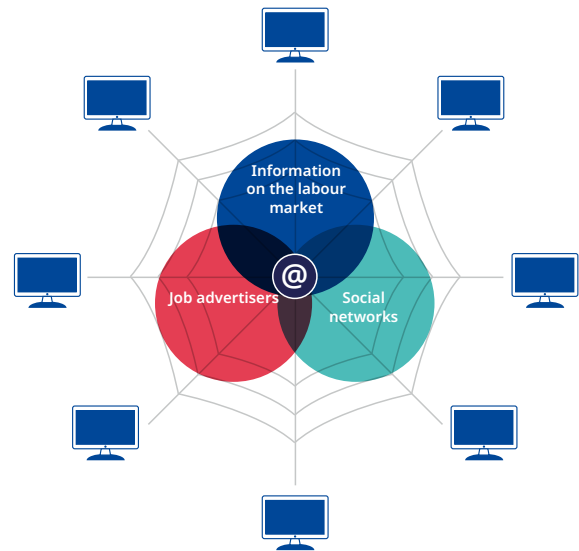
- ✓ **Finding information on the labour market:** statistical data, job descriptions, reports on economic sectors, information on each company and so on.
- ✓ **Finding and applying for jobs:** almost all job offers are published on the Internet nowadays (PES Internet portal, specialized private sites and company sites). It is possible to create a profile, subscribe to offers, apply online and so on.
- ✓ **Build your network and make yourself known:** as we have shown above, the importance of networking is undeniable. However, it is important to make the best use of them, particularly those aimed at professionals such as LinkedIn or Viadeo.



As an employment counsellor, you will have to make jobseekers aware of the importance of the Internet in their job search, accompany them in the optimal use of these three functionalities, while at the same time warning them about the risks that the Internet represents: scams, fraud and overexposure of privacy. The topic of e-reputation is an important subject in the advice that you will give.

## ► Developing a jobseeking strategy (pages 29–33 of the guide)

During the three previous phases, you have accompanied the jobseeker in building their jobseeking tools; you have explained to them how the labour market works and demonstrated the importance of making the best use of all of the functionalities of the Internet. They are therefore almost ready to put everything they have learned into practice and start their job search. One last essential stage remains: that of preparing their strategy. An effective job search requires a well thought-out strategy.



- ✓ **Targeting companies to contact:** in the guide, you will find a methodology to explain to the jobseeker. This is primarily based on defining “their own labour market” and then identifying and prioritizing companies to approach.
- ✓ **Managing your job search – organising your time:** the guide also provides grids and tools that will help the jobseeker to adopt an efficient method.

As an employment counsellor, you can also complement this methodological approach by sharing your knowledge of the local labour market, business trends and economic projects. From this phase onwards, your role changes. The follow-up meetings and contacts that you will have with the person will mainly be devoted to a debriefing on their job searches and applications, possibly including the identification of peripheral obstacles to their job search that you had not yet identified and which should be taken into consideration.

## ► Integrating into the company (pages 35 to 39 of the guide)

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The counsellor's role does not end when the jobseeker receives a positive response. It is certainly very good news for the jobseeker and will bring you great satisfaction in your daily work as a counsellor; however, it is still necessary to secure the job to ensure a sustainable return to employment.

Your role as counsellor may focus on two aspects:

- ✓ **Counselling support in negotiating the employment contract:** You may not be an expert in labour law, but you can help with the thinking. The elements on page 37 of the reference guide will guide your advice: find out about the company's practices, prepare an argument for the negotiation of pay and working conditions and so on.
- ✓ **Preparation for integration into the company:** Signing a new employment contract marks the culmination of the job search process, but the goal will only have been achieved if the job is sustainable. This implies finding one's place and legitimacy in the company, in the work team, by meeting the employer's expectations and deriving satisfaction from the new position. As a counsellor, you must make the individual aware of how to prepare for the job. This mainly involves applying behavioural skills that are appropriate to life in a company..





# Part 3



## ENVIRONMENTAL ELEMENTS

10. Acting with companies

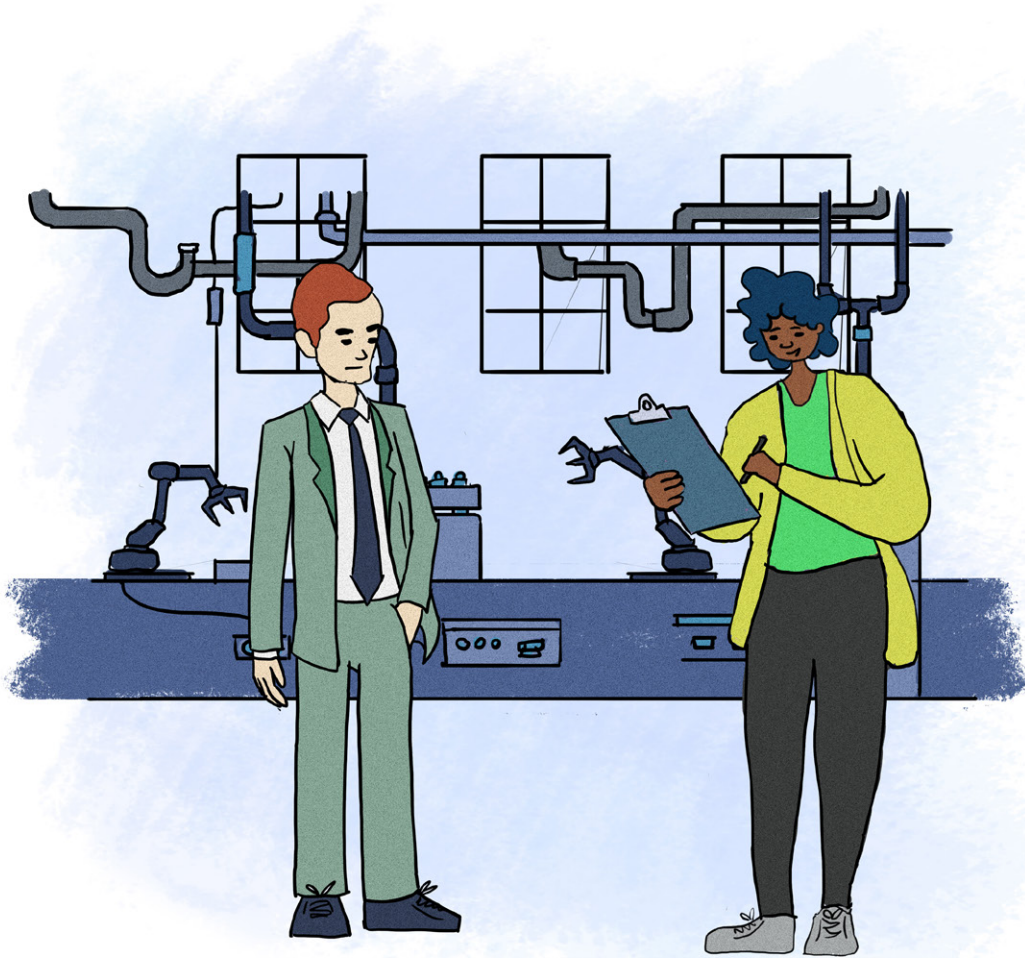
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11. Acting in partnership

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# ▶ 10 Acting with companies

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Organizational choices of the PES to meet employers' expectations

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Roles, stances and activities of the dedicated employer counsellor

This guide is dedicated to supporting the jobseeker, so some may ask why this chapter is dedicated to working with companies. Because the purpose of an employment service is to intermediate between employment supply and demand, it is important that each counsellor understands how the service to recruiters should be organized.

## ► Organizational choices of the PES to meet employers' expectations

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- In parts 1 and 2 of this guide, we have already presented some conceptual and methodological elements related to business services. While everyone understands that the mission of intermediating between employment supply and demand requires the working relationships with employers and jobseekers to be equally intense, a real imbalance can be observed in almost all countries. Indeed, typically, all too few employers entrust their job offers to the PES.

There are two main reasons for this:

- Lack of information and visibility regarding the PES service offer. In many countries, the public employment service is not known or identified by employers as being able to offer them services relating to recruitment. They think that the PES is mainly focused on offering welfare-related services to the unemployed and less qualified.
- Lack of trust. Those employers who are aware of the existence of PES mostly perceive it to be a cumbersome and restrictive bureaucratic structure that is unable to offer them relevant profiles quickly. They prefer to go to private employment agencies, which of course charge a fee but which they feel are better able to understand their issues.

## What are employers' expectations (private companies or public employers)?

The needs of a VSE (Very Small Enterprise) with 5 employees, in which the boss has to do everything, and an SME (Small or Medium-sized Enterprise) with 220 employees and its own human resources department are obviously different their expectations are often similar. They can be summarized in four points:

- Ease of contact and a single point of contact: as soon as a need arises, employers want to be able to contact their counsellor quickly (by telephone or email) and always keep the same contact person.
- Knowledge of the company and its businesses: employers want a relationship of trust with their counsellors and expect them to understand their business, the challenges of their professional sector and the company's professions, in order to support their projects.
- Reactivity and efficiency: the employer expects an immediate response to their order, relevant and useful advice on the formulation of their job offer and rapid results.
- Suitable candidate profiles: the employer usually expects the PES to pre-screen applications, in order to save time by receiving only a limited number of relevant profiles for consideration.

## Organization of the PES

Over the last few decades, different organizational choices have been trialled by the PES to meet employers' expectations. Two modalities are used:

- The multi-skilled counsellor: This modality is based on the idea that the counsellor, in order to achieve quality intermediation, must be as familiar with jobseekers' profiles as with companies' needs. For example, in some PES, employment counsellors divide their time between monitoring a portfolio of jobseekers and supporting a portfolio of companies. This is often accompanied by sectoral specialization. For example, the counsellor will focus specifically on the construction or catering sector. They will be required to develop their expertise in this sector: knowledge of these professions, seasonal recruitment, expected skills, professional regulations, training and so on.
- The dedicated business counsellor: On the other hand, PES that choose to specialize their counsellors feel that the job is too vast for their agents to master all of its facets perfectly. Some counsellors are therefore dedicated to supporting jobseekers, others to managing compensation and still others to serving employers and companies.



## ► Roles, stances and activities of the dedicated employer counsellor

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All of the elements presented in chapter 4 of this guide are valid for dedicated employer counsellors. We invite you to reread them. In particular, we reaffirm the following: "An expert in their field, they greet their client, listen to their expressed expectations and ask questions to identify and define their real need, before recommending a service or product suited to the individual's needs. They provide the client with useful information and can, if necessary, refer them to other more relevant contact persons. They are guided in their actions by concern for client satisfaction."

### In addition to the core professional skills of the counsellor, the employer counsellor will need to acquire new skills:

- **Knowledge of the business world:** the counsellor must learn and understand the economic and social operation of a private company. If they have not already worked in the private sector, it is advisable to allow them to complete one or more immersion and discovery placements in a company.
- **Commercial approach:** In order to speak a common language with the employer and to know how to present arguments concerning their service offer while prospecting, it is useful for the counsellor to be trained in the commercial approach. This implies negotiation skills.
- **Information and economic monitoring:** In order to develop and maintain their thematic and/or sectoral expertise, counsellors must continuously monitor current events in their employment area, the life of companies, the evolution of professions and products and the like. They must be curious about economic and social current affairs, consult statistics on the labour market, read the regional, national and specialized press and so on.

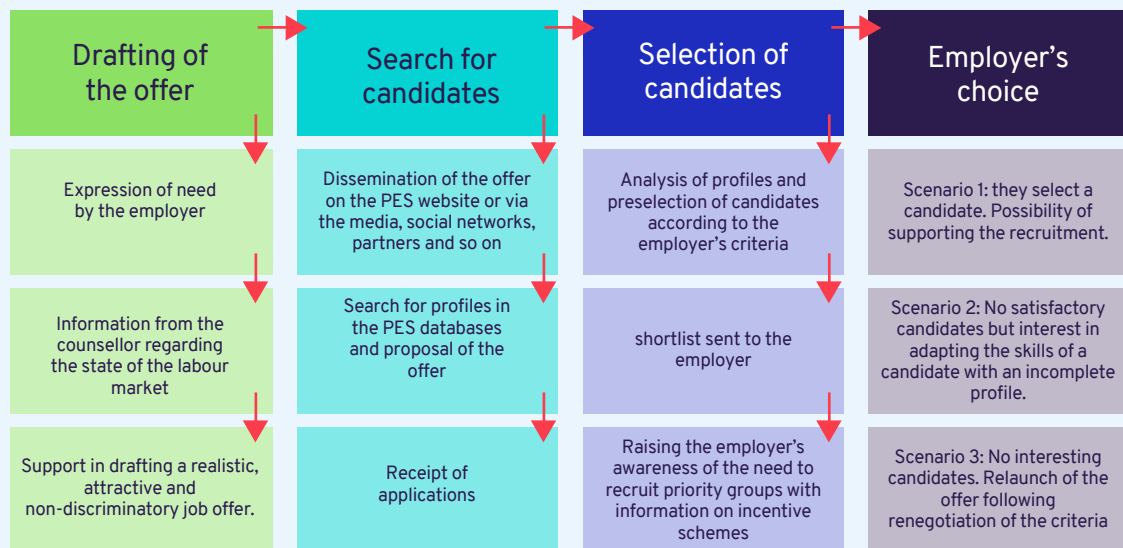
Employment counsellors are often apprehensive about their relationship with the employer. They often feel an inferiority complex towards the manager. A solid training programme and development of their expertise will enable them to approach the relationship with more confidence.

### Main activities of the dedicated employer counsellor

- Typically, about 80 per cent of the relationship with the employer is related to recruitment and particularly to the processing of a job offer (see process below). However, the counsellor has other functions:
- **Prospection:** according to a predefined strategy, visiting companies in the employment area to identify their needs and promote the PES service offer. The dedicated counsellor should create a long-lasting and trusting relationship with the main employers in their portfolio, visiting them regularly, which allows them to stay informed about news and trends in their employment area.
- **Recruitment management:** processing job offers
- **Implementation of recruitment assistance schemes:** financial aid offered by the government to encourage the hiring of priority groups or the adaptation of skills to the needs of companies.
- **Job study:** prior to mass recruitment, taking the time to analyse the position to be filled in the company, using a specific methodology, in order to optimize the sourcing of candidates.

- Organization of recruitment forums (some of which are online)
- Organization and supervision of professional training courses to deal with professions in short supply.
- Support for the company's projects: in the context of building customer loyalty, a long-term relationship makes it possible to be informed of medium- and long-term projects (expansion/new activity) and to anticipate labour needs with the company, in order to prepare candidates. In other cases, it may be a case of supporting more complex projects, such as redundancy plans.

► **Process of handling a job offer**





# ▶ 11 Acting in partnership

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Identifying external actors

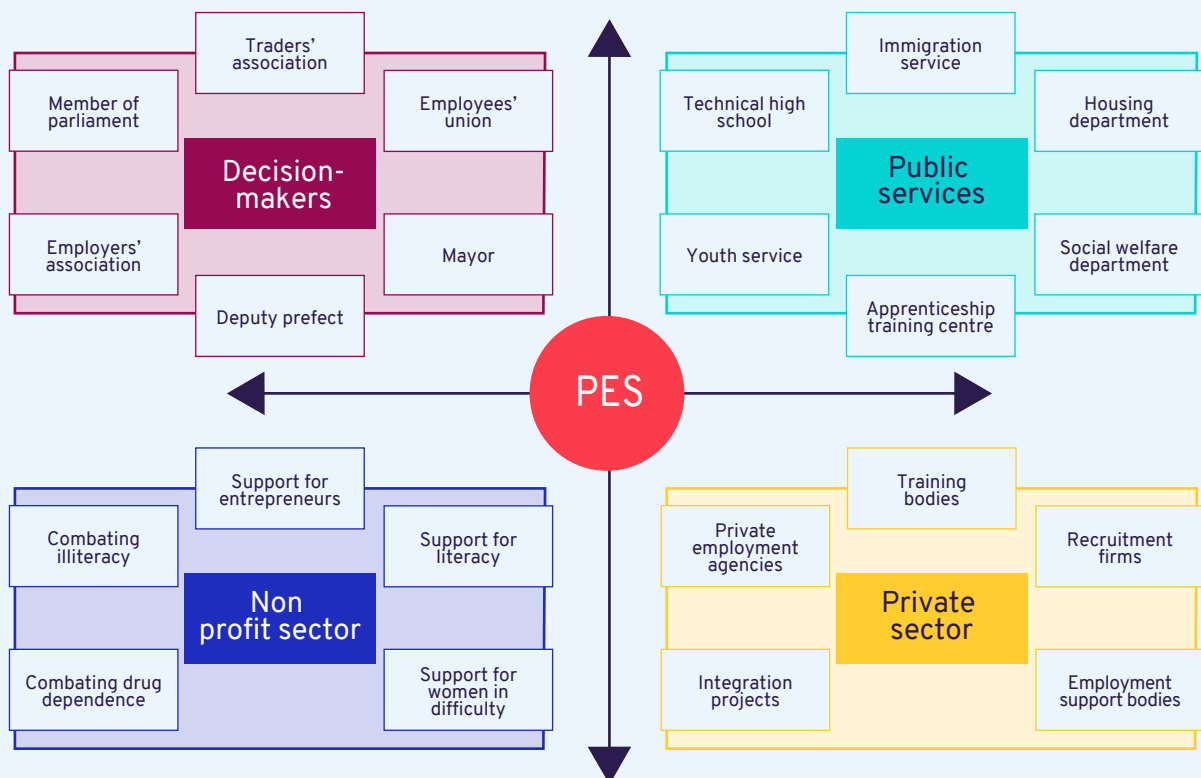
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Acting in complementarity

Professional integration counsellors cannot work alone. If they relied solely on their own actions and knowledge, they would lose relevance and effectiveness.

- ✓ **Internally, in their employment agency**, they act in collaboration with their colleagues. The expertise of each member of the team is an asset in providing the best service to each user. Complementarity is essential. Counsellor cannot have answers to all of the questions of the people they support. Rather than giving an approximate answer, they should delay their answer and go and ask their colleagues. The practice exchange sessions organized within an employment service are a very useful way of sharing experiences and developing skills.
- ✓ **Externally, they are surrounded by a network of actors in their employment area**, who intervene in the field of employment and socioprofessional integration. These structures can be very helpful in finding solutions for PES clients. It is essential to identify them, to understand their role in the territory, their service offer and their mode of operation

## ► Identifying external actors



We can distinguish four families of actors developing around the employment service:

- ✓ **Decision-makers:** Representatives of the State, local elected representatives, consular chambers, employers' unions, professional branches and so on.
- ✓ **Public services:** Social welfare, youth, housing, health, education and other services.
- ✓ **Non-profit sector:** support for women in difficulty, combating illiteracy, combating addictions and so on.
- ✓ **Private sector:** Private employment and temp agencies, training organizations, support providers and so on.

Their representation in the form of a sociogram (below) enables you to identify the influence of each actor and their importance in relation to the PES.

## ► Acting in complementarity

The professional integration counsellor acts on professional integration and this can be hindered by a number of obstacles. Some of these will be related to your area of expertise (career guidance, job search techniques, access to vacancies and so on) and you will be able to guide the individual through them. Other obstacles will be peripheral, often of a social nature (health, housing, childcare, mobility, addictions and so on) and outside your field of competence. You will have to identify a relevant partner structure for that area and refer the person to the right contact person who can support them.

In order to know which partner to refer your user to, it is very useful to have an identification tool. The example in the table below can be adapted.

| Structure     | Skills                          | Address and tel.           | Contact @        | Service offer                                                                                                                         | Referral arrangements for the public.     |
|---------------|---------------------------------|----------------------------|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Social Centre | Health, accommodation, family.. | Rue du port...<br>23569847 | Cs.inf@ville.net | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Health check-up</li> <li>• Emergency accommodation</li> <li>• Child protection...</li> </ul> | Make an appointment for the user by phone |

It is important to refer the individual under appropriate conditions in order to optimize the effectiveness of the intervention. This means:

- ✓ **Shared diagnosis:** the counsellor and the jobseeker agree on the obstacle that has been identified.
- ✓ **Presentation of the partner:** the counsellor presents the partner structure to the jobseeker, explaining its role and the type of services it offers
- ✓ **Adherence to the approach:** the jobseeker accepts the referral to the partner

- ✓ **Transmission of information to the partner:** the counsellor will inform the partner of the jobseeker's situation and the type of service expected. When the partnership is formalized between the two structures, this transmission of information can take the form of a liaison form (paper or digital).
- ✓ **Follow-up:** The jobseeker or the partner (if authorized by the jobseeker) will inform the counsellor of the steps taken and the progress made in removing the obstacles identified.

Some countries have developed a “global” or “holistic” approach to support. This consists in considering the individual as a whole and coordinating the intervention of the various support staff around them.

## ► Conclusion

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Like many service professions, working as an employment counsellor requires good theoretical, technical and interpersonal skills. This handbook provides a solid foundation, which can be adapted to your professional context and the realities of your country. We urge you to support your colleagues and management in this.

Mastering the job of an employment counsellor takes time and a lot of practice. Throughout your career, you will need to update your skills to maintain your level of expertise. With this in mind, in this manual, we suggest some of the ways in which this can be done.

► **Exchanges of practices:** whether these are organized in a formal or informal setting, it is important that you discuss your lived professional situations (problematic or otherwise) with your colleagues. This enables you:

- ✓ To benefit from your peers' views on how you have dealt with a situation
- ✓ To discover their way of working and new approaches
- ✓ To relieve the stress of certain difficult situations
- ✓ To share tips, resources, addresses and so on.

► **Information monitoring:** you are operating in a changing environment. In order to be able to give counsel in a relevant way, it is essential that you keep yourself informed on a number of topics:

- ✓ National, regional and local economic news (business life)
- ✓ News from partners in the employment catchment area
- ✓ The local and regional training offer
- ✓ The evolution of professions (regulations, skills and so on)
- ✓ Market trends: professions in demand, salary trends and so on.

► **Continuing education:**

- ✓ Take training courses on changes in your profession and your working environment, on stance, leadership, stress management and so on.
- ✓ Internal IT: maintain or improve your command of the digital tools needed for your daily work
- ✓ External IT: maintain your knowledge of the digital media offered by your employment service so that you can explain them to jobseekers and employers.

Like other professions, that of employment counsellor is changing rapidly. The COVID-19 pandemic, for example, has pushed each of us to learn to work with remote communication tools within a very short time. As for the climate crisis, it requires us to support changes in the economy towards more sustainable activities. Like all workers, employment counsellors therefore have to update their skills continuously to maintain a good level of expertise and relevance.

Below is a list of the sources used for this guide, as well as some useful further reading.

## ► Sources used:

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- (12): Skills expected by employers [Les compétences attendues par les employeurs - Pôle emploi | pole-emploi.org](#)

## Useful reading:

- Practitioners’ guides on employment service centres: Training of trainers on operations, counselling, and employer services (Volume 1) (ilo.org)
- Practitioners’ guides on employment service centres: Operating employment service centres (Volume 2) (ilo.org)
- Practitioners’ guides on employment service centres: Providing effective counselling services (Volume 3) (ilo.org)
- Practitioners’ guides on employment service centres: Providing effective employer services (Volume 4) (ilo.org)
- Public Employment Service Training Guideline Presentation (ilo.org)
- Fundamental rights and principles at work (ilo.org)

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